

THE EMERGENCY FOOD PLAYBOOK

30 Days of Affordable, High-Protein Meals for Power Outages, Hurricanes, Winter Storms and Supply Disruptions — built from ordinary grocery-store food, not survival buckets.

70

shelf-stable recipes with
water and fuel counts

30 days

menu system with rotation
built in

10

disaster-specific playbooks

\$0 panic

calm, sourced, budget-first
planning

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U.S. EDITION · LETTER SIZE

The Complete U.S. Household System

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Copyright

The Emergency Food Playbook: 30 Days of Affordable, High-Protein Meals for Power Outages, Hurricanes, Winter Storms and Supply Disruptions. First edition, 2026.

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All recipes in this book are original formulations using shelf-stable grocery ingredients. Product names that may appear (for example, brand names of canned meats or boxed meals) are referenced generically and are trademarks of their respective owners; no endorsement or affiliation is implied.

Safety information reflects U.S. federal guidance (USDA, FDA, FEMA, CDC, EPA) and university-extension publications available at the time of writing. Guidance can change; where this book and current official guidance differ, follow current official guidance and the instructions on your own products.

Prices, costs and availability are variable and given only as rough planning examples. Nothing in this book is medical advice.

Printed and formatted for U.S. Letter paper (8.5 × 11 in).

Disclaimer

This book is general educational information about household food preparedness. It is not medical, nutritional or safety advice, and it does not guarantee outcomes in any emergency. Every household, home, climate and disaster is different.

- Consult a physician, registered dietitian or pediatrician before changing anyone's diet, and always for infant feeding, pregnancy, kidney disease, diabetes, heart conditions, sodium-restricted diets, allergies or any medical diet.
- Never dilute infant formula. Ready-to-feed formula is the safest emergency option per CDC guidance.
- Follow current USDA, FDA, FEMA/Ready.gov, CDC, EPA and local public-health guidance. This book cannot update itself; you can.
- Verify every product you buy: serving sizes, nutrition, allergens, dates and preparation instructions come from the label in your hands, not from this book.
- Food safety rules in this book assume U.S. household conditions. When in doubt, throw it out.

If someone may be in danger

Call 911 for life-threatening emergencies. For possible poisoning (including suspected carbon monoxide or chemical exposure), call Poison Control at 1-800-222-1222. For local assistance during and after disasters, call 211.

How to Use This Book

This book is a system, not a shopping list. It teaches your household to buy, store, cook and rotate emergency food on a normal grocery budget — then practice it without stress.

Read in this order the first time

- 1. **Chapters 1–2:** the problem and the three-layer pantry model — five minutes each.
- 2. **Chapter 4:** your first week of shopping. Stop reading and go buy Week 1.
- 3. **Chapters 5–7:** the meals and the 30-day menu, once your first supplies are home.
- 4. **Everything else** is reference material — return to it as you build.

How to read recipe cards

Every recipe carries the same spec strip, so you can plan without surprises:

METHOD	No-cook · Hot-water · One-pot (see the method key in Chapter 5)
WATER	Approximate water needed, and whether it is absorbed, drained or creates dishwater
FUEL	No-cook · Hot water only · Low · Moderate · High
DISHES	Number of pots/bowls to wash — 0 means eat from the package

Nutrition is deliberately not printed on cards. Brands differ enormously; the only honest instruction is: **check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.**

The icons

Water drop = water required · flame = fuel required · pot = one pot · clock = prep time · alert = safety note. All worksheets in Chapter 12 and the back matter are designed to print cleanly on this same Letter paper.

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Chapter recipe and playbook pages follow each chapter opening (the running headers show where you are); the recipe index at the back lists all 70 recipes with water, fuel and dish counts.

Emergency Safety Notice

Carbon monoxide kills quietly

Never run a generator, charcoal grill, camp stove, propane heater or any fuel-burning device indoors, in a garage, or in any enclosed or partially enclosed space unless it is specifically approved for that environment and used exactly as directed. Run generators outdoors at least 20 feet from windows, doors and vents, with exhaust pointed away. Keep a battery-powered or battery-backup carbon monoxide alarm working whenever a generator is in use. Symptoms — headache, dizziness, weakness, nausea, confusion — mean get into fresh air immediately and call 911.

The five numbers that protect your food

4 hours	How long a closed refrigerator keeps food safely cold (USDA). After that, discard refrigerated perishables.
48 / 24 hours	How long a closed full / half-full freezer keeps food safely frozen (USDA).
40 °F	The cold line. Perishables held above 40 °F too long are discarded — never taste to check.
140 °F	The hot line. Keep hot food at or above 140 °F; the 40–140 °F range is the bacterial Danger Zone.
2 hours	Maximum time perishable food sits out — 1 hour when the air is above 90 °F (USDA).

Water rules

When authorities issue a boil-water advisory, boil water at a rolling boil for 1 minute (3 minutes above 6,500 feet) or disinfect per the EPA table in Chapter 3. During a flood, assume floodwater is contaminated: discard any food it touched unless it is in a sealed waterproof can, and follow the salvage steps in Chapter 9. Never ration drinking water — drink what you need today and find more for tomorrow (FEMA).

Full source citations appear in Chapter 13 and the Sources section.

Quick-Start Checklist

Do these ten things in the next two weeks. Total cost can be under \$30 if you spread it across one normal grocery run. This is the 72-hour foundation — Chapter 4 builds it out to 30 days.

Done	Action	Notes
☐	Store 3 gallons of water per person (3-day supply), or buy an equivalent case of bottled water	
☐	Put a manual can opener with the emergency food — plus a backup	
☐	Buy 9 no-cook meals your family already likes (see Chapter 5)	
☐	Buy shelf-stable protein: 4 cans tuna/chicken, 1 jar peanut butter, 2 cans beans	
☐	Check that smoke and carbon monoxide alarms work; add batteries to your kit	
☐	Put an appliance thermometer in the refrigerator and freezer today	
☐	Freeze two jugs of water to extend freezer cold-time and use as cooler ice	
☐	Note where you would cook outdoors 20+ feet from the house	
☐	Fill the pantry inventory sheet (back matter) with what you just bought	
☐	Pick one Saturday this month to eat a pantry meal as practice	

Progress beats perfection. A household that stores three days of food it actually eats is better prepared than one with an untouched 30-day bucket it cannot afford.

CHAPTER 1

The Emergency-Food Problem

Why most households are one storm away from an empty table — and why neither the mega shopping list nor the survival bucket is the right answer.

The gap nobody talks about

American households face a quiet contradiction when they look into emergency food. On one side are generic prepper lists: fifty items, bulk buckets, grain barrels — plenty of telling people *what to buy*, almost no guidance on what to actually do with it when the power is out, the kids are hungry and the stove is cold. On the other side are commercial freeze-dried buckets: convenient and long-lasting, but often expensive per calorie, unfamiliar to picky eaters, and sometimes heavy on sodium.

Between those two poles sits the reality of most U.S. households: a normal grocery budget, a normal pantry, and normal disasters — a storm that knocks the power out for two days, an ice storm that closes the roads for a week, a hurricane evacuation, a supply hiccup at the store, a paycheck that arrives late. FEMA and Ready.gov encourage every household to keep at least several days of shelf-stable food and water, and to plan toward two weeks where practical.

This book lives in that gap. Its promise is simple: help an ordinary household build an affordable emergency food supply from grocery-store items — the same brands on your shelf today — and turn those items into real meals during power outages, hurricanes, winter storms, wildfires, tornadoes, earthquakes and short-term supply disruptions. No apocalypse talk. No miracle foods. Just planning.

What "prepared" actually means here

Preparedness in this book means four concrete abilities. You can: (1) feed everyone in your household for at least 72 hours with zero cooking, zero electricity and minimal water; (2) keep feeding them for up to 30 days using shelf-stable meals you have tasted and approved; (3) keep the food fresh through rotation instead of letting it expire untouched; and (4) do all of that on a budget that fits inside a normal grocery run.

Notice what is missing from that definition: guarantees. Nobody can guarantee outcomes in a disaster. What you can control is readiness — and readiness built from food you already eat is cheaper, tastier and far more likely to actually get used.

The five real problems this book solves

Problem	Why it happens	Where it's solved
Not knowing what to buy first	Lists arrive all at once, dozens of items deep, with no sequence	Chapters 2 & 4 — a buying order and staged plans
Freeze-dried buckets are expensive	Per-serving cost runs far above grocery staples	Chapter 4 — honest cost comparison and hybrid strategy
Food bought but never eaten	Supplies sit untouched until they expire	Chapters 7 & 9 — rotation and the monthly pantry meal
Families reject "survival food"	Unfamiliar, bland, or too-adult flavors	Chapter 8 — familiar meals, build-your-own formats, scorecards
Meals assume a working kitchen	Microwaves, fridges and electric stoves disappear first	Chapters 5, 6 & 10 — no-cook, hot-water and one-pot systems

A note on tone

You will not find collapse predictions or life-saving superfoods in this book. Preparedness is household resilience: fewer wasted dollars, calmer decisions, and dinner on the table when the grid hiccups. Everything here works just as well for a snow day or a tight week in the budget as it does for a hurricane.

CHAPTER 2

The Three-Layer Pantry

A simple model that tells you exactly what to buy first, what to buy later, and what not to buy yet.

Three layers, one rule

Build the pantry in layers, from foods that need **nothing** to foods that need **time and fuel**. The single rule: **store what you eat; eat what you store**. Every item in every layer should be something your household would happily eat on an ordinary Tuesday.

Layer	Covers	What it holds	Needs
Layer 1 — Ready	Hours 0–72	No-cook meals, ready-to-eat protein, crackers, nut butters, shelf milk, fruit cups, jerky, granola, water	Nothing — no heat, no water beyond drinking
Layer 2 — Transition	Days 2–14	Hot-water meals (couscous, instant rice, oats, ramen), one-pot canned meals, sauces, seasonings, comfort foods	Hot water or one burner, modest fuel
Layer 3 — Deep	Days 7–30+	Dry staples (rice, pasta, oats, beans, lentils), baking staples, powdered milk and eggs, bulk formats	Real cooking, more water and fuel

Why layers matter

Most outages end before Layer 3 is ever touched — but they always start in Layer 1. A household with deep storage and no ready layer eats cold beans with no can opener; a household with only snack bars runs out of dinner by day two. Layers fix both failure modes.

Buy this first · buy later · not yet

Buy this first (days 1–14 of building)	Buy later (weeks 2–4)	Do not buy yet
Bottled or stored water · manual can opener · ready-to-eat proteins (tuna, chicken, peanut butter, jerky, canned beans) · crackers and tortillas · shelf-stable milk · canned fruit and vegetables · no-cook meals your family already likes	Instant rice, couscous, quick oats, instant potatoes · pasta, sauces, canned soups · cooking oil · seasonings · comfort foods · a camp stove and fuel if you have outdoor space	55-gallon drums and bulk grain before you have rotation habits · freeze-dried cases you cannot afford · appliances (dehydrators, freeze-dryers) · any item your family has never tasted

Water, protein, calories, sanitation — in that order

When money or shelf space is tight, priority runs in this order: **water first** (you can go weeks without a shopping cart, but only days without water), then **ready-to-eat protein** (it requires no cooking when the stove is dead), then **calories from familiar carbohydrates**, then **a way to heat water**, and finally **sanitation supplies** — hand sanitizer, disposable gloves, trash bags, paper plates — because an emergency kitchen is also a hygiene problem.

FEMA's baseline is one gallon of water per person per day for drinking and sanitation, with at least a several-day supply on hand and two weeks as a practical goal. Chapter 3 turns that number into a household-specific plan.

The budget truth

You do not need a dedicated "emergency budget." You need a grocery budget with a rotation habit: every week, one or two extra shelf-stable items go in; every week, one pantry meal comes out. Chapter 4 shows the math.

Layer targets at a glance

Per person, approximate planning quantities for shelf-stable food. These are planning starting points, not prescriptions — adjust for appetite, age, climate and activity. Calories and protein are planning aids only; verify nutrition on your actual product labels.

Per-person targets by layer

Layer	Food target (per person)	Water target
Layer 1 — Ready (72 h)	About 9 ready-to-eat meals/snack-meals totaling roughly 4,500–6,000 calories, including 45–60 g protein per day from tuna pouches, nut butters, jerky, beans or shelf milk	3 gallons (1 gal/day)
Layer 2 — Transition (days 2–14)	About 12–18 hot meals: quick grains, canned meal starters, sauces and seasonings — roughly 1,500–2,000 calories per person per day as the mix widens	Add 7–11 gallons
Layer 3 — Deep (days 7–30+)	Dry staples to complete 30 days: rice, pasta, oats, beans, lentils, powdered milk/egg, oil — the full menu grid in Chapter 7 shows how it assembles	Add through the 30-day total in Chapter 3

Rule of thumb

A typical adult eats about 3 cans of food plus some dry staples per day across two hot meals and breakfast, and a family of four goes through roughly 20–25 cans in the first week alone. Buy toward those numbers gradually — never all at once.

CHAPTER 3

Quantities, Calories and Water

How much food is enough, how much water it takes, and how to plan for the people actually living in your house.

There is no single "correct" number

Emergency-planning sites often publish one universal calorie figure. That is a shortcut, not a fact. Energy needs vary with age, sex, body size, activity, climate and health. The USDA's Dietary Guidelines put typical adult needs in ranges — roughly 1,600–2,400 calories per day for women and 2,000–3,000 for men — and children's needs anywhere from about 1,000 to 3,200 depending on age and activity. Pregnancy and breastfeeding raise needs further; a clinician is the right source for those plans.

Use calories and protein as **planning aids**, then verify against the labels of the products you actually buy. A sensible planning posture: target roughly 1,800–2,200 calories and 50–60 g of protein per adult per day in your menu math, scale children down by appetite, and adjust upward for hard physical work or cold weather. The FDA Daily Values are a handy yardstick on labels: 2,300 mg sodium, 50 g protein, 28 g fiber and 50 g added sugar each represent a full day's benchmark on a 2,000-calorie reference diet.

Planning tables

Shelf-stable food planning totals (per person, approximate)

Duration	Calories to plan	Protein target	Ready meals	Hot meals	Typical cans/dry goods
72 hours	5,400–6,600	150–180 g	9	0–2	~9–12 items
7 days	12,600–15,400	350–420 g	9	8–12	~25–35 items
14 days	25,200–30,800	700–840 g	9	20–26	~50–70 items
30 days	54,000–66,000	1,500–1,800 g	9	~45–55	~100–140 items

Children: scale by appetite — many children eat roughly half an adult portion, toddlers less. Older adults often need fewer calories but the same protein density. Pregnant or nursing adults, people with diabetes, kidney disease or other conditions: build these numbers with a clinician.

Water is the real emergency food

FEMA's planning baseline is **one gallon per person per day** — about half a gallon for drinking and half for food preparation and sanitation. That is a floor, not a ceiling: hot weather, physical work, pregnancy, illness and children's activity all push needs up. Ready.gov recommends storing at least a several-day supply and working toward two weeks per person; store more if space and budget allow. And one FEMA rule deserves bold type: **never ration drinking water** — drink what you need today, then find more for tomorrow.

Budget water in four columns: **drinking**, **cooking** (grains and pasta drink water you can see; check each recipe's spec strip), **sanitation** (handwashing, dish cleanup, hygiene) and **pets** — dogs and cats need their own supply, roughly one ounce of water per pound of body weight per day as a rule of thumb, more in heat.

Water storage calculator (people × days × 1 gallon)

Household	72 hours	7 days	14 days	30 days
1 person	3 gal	7 gal	14 gal	30 gal
2 people	6 gal	14 gal	28 gal	60 gal
Family of 4	12 gal	28 gal	56 gal	120 gal
Family of 4 + medium dog	14 gal	32 gal	62 gal	130+ gal

Add extra in hot climates or for high activity — many households plan 1.5 gallons per person per day in summer. A printable version of this calculator is in the back matter.

What to store

The simplest, most reliable supply is **commercially bottled water** in its original sealed containers — buy it, date it, rotate it, and follow the date on the bottle. For self-stored tap water use food-grade containers (PETE plastic jugs with tight caps are common); thoroughly washed and sanitized first. Never reuse containers that held milk, juice or chemicals — milk residues foster bacteria and chemical residues do not fully rinse out. Store water in a cool, dark place; light and heat shorten its life. Rotate self-stored water about every six months; unopened commercial bottles follow their printed dates.

If storage space is short, remember other sources exist — but they need treatment: the hot-water tank (switch off its power or gas first and close the inlet valve), and ice frozen in advance in jugs and bags, which doubles as cooler fuel. Do not count on the tap: pressure can fail without warning.

Making questionable water safe

Approved treatment methods (EPA / CDC)

Method	How	Notes
Boiling	Rolling boil for 1 full minute; 3 minutes above 6,500 ft elevation	Kills bacteria, viruses and parasites; the surest method when fuel allows. A lid saves fuel.
Household bleach	Plain, unscented, 5–9% sodium hypochlorite only. Clear water: 8 drops (about ½ tsp) per gallon of 6% bleach — 6 drops if 8.25%. Cloudy water: filter first, then double the dose. Stir; wait 30 minutes.	Water should smell faintly of chlorine afterward; if not, repeat the dose once, wait 15 more minutes, and if still no smell, discard and find another source. Bleach loses strength — replace yearly.
Purification tablets	Follow the product label exactly	Good for go-bags; check expiration dates.
Bottled water	Drink first, treat later	If you have sealed bottles, use them before treating questionable water.

Floodwater is contaminated water

After flooding, assume water touching your home is contaminated with sewage, fuel or chemicals. Do not use it for drinking, cooking or washing dishes without treatment — and note that boiling does not remove chemical contaminants: if authorities issue a "do not drink" advisory, only sealed bottled water is safe. Discard any food touched by floodwater (salvage rules for sealed cans are in Chapter 9). Keep children and pets away from standing floodwater.

Track the burn rate

During an event, mark each opened gallon jug with the date. Seeing real consumption against your table replaces anxiety with arithmetic.

CHAPTER 4

Build Your Shopping Plan

A four-week staged build — water first, then meals, then depth — with a budget version and an honest look at freeze-dried food.

The four-week build

Four shopping trips, each inside a normal grocery run. Amounts below are for a family of four; single and two-person households should halve or quarter food quantities (water: see the calculator in Chapter 3). Prices are rough 2020s U.S. ranges and vary by region, store and season.

Staged build — what each week buys

Week	Buy	Approx. cost*
Week 1	Water (2 cases bottled or 2 jugs/person), manual can opener + backup, ready-to-eat protein (tuna pouches, canned chicken, peanut butter, jerky), no-cook staples (crackers, granola, shelf milk, fruit cups), sanitation basics (sanitizer, trash bags, paper plates)	\$40–60
Week 2	Quick staples: instant rice, couscous, quick oats, instant potatoes, pasta, ramen; canned and dry beans, lentils; canned vegetables, tomatoes and fruit	\$35–55
Week 3	Flavor and comfort: oil, tomato sauces, salsa, bouillon, taco/Italian seasonings, shelf milk cartons, powdered milk, mac and cheese, pancake mix, honey, candy, coffee, tea	\$30–50
Week 4	Capability: camp-stove fuel (or charcoal), thermos, storage bins, printed inventory sheets, special-diet items	\$35–70

*Rough ranges only — prices vary by store, brand and region. Store brands routinely cost 20–40% less for identical staples; compare unit prices (per ounce), not package prices.

The \$10-per-week version

On a tight budget, buy one or two extra shelf-stable items per regular trip — a can of beans here, a pouch of tuna there — and add one gallon jug of water monthly. Rotation (Chapter 9) turns that trickle into a real supply within a season. If you receive SNAP/EBT or WIC benefits, ask your local office how disaster replacement benefits work in your state, and prioritize shelf-stable proteins and produce (canned) when the budget is thin.

Freeze-dried buckets versus groceries: the honest math

Commercial freeze-dried and dehydrated meals have genuine strengths: very long stated shelf lives (often measured in years to decades, depending on brand and packaging), zero planning at cooking time, and portability. They are also usually several times more expensive per serving than the grocery staples that replace them, their flavors can be unfamiliar to children, and sodium levels vary widely by brand — check labels like any other food.

The grocery pantry's strengths are the mirror image: pennies per serving for rice, oats, beans and pasta; flavors your household already likes; and rotation that refunds its own cost as you eat what you store. Its weaknesses: you must supply the water, fuel and know-how, and shelf lives of everyday packaging are measured in months and years, not decades.

The practical answer for most households is a hybrid: grocery staples as the foundation, plus a small amount of commercial product where it genuinely earns its price — a go-bag meal, an evacuation-ready entrée, a backup for households with no cooking option at all. Never attack-or-buy in panic; test one item of any brand before committing money, and read the nutrition and sodium figures before stocking cases.

Cost per meal — typical ranges (variable; verify current prices)

Approach	Typical cost per adult serving	Best use
Grocery staples you rotate (rice, beans, oats, canned goods)	~\$0.75–\$2.00	Foundation of the 30-day plan
Grocery comfort meals (canned soups, chili, pasta kits)	~\$1.50–\$3.00	Transition layer, morale
Commercial freeze-dried buckets / pouches	~\$3.00–\$8.00+	Long-term backup, go-bags, no-cook-capability households

Taste-test before you stock

Buy one unit of anything new, cook it on an ordinary night, and score it on the taste-test sheet in the back matter. If the household rates it below four out of five, it does not earn shelf space — no matter the bargain. This one habit prevents the most expensive mistake in preparedness: food nobody eats.

CHAPTER 5

No-Cook Meals

Twenty-two meals that need no heat, no electricity and barely any water — the layer that carries the first 72 hours.

Six ways a meal can work without power

Meal class	Definition	When it's the right choice
No-cook	Assembly only — open, mix, eat	Any outage; the first 24 hours especially
Ready-to-eat	Fully cooked in the can or pouch (canned chicken, ham, chili)	When protein is the priority
Hot-water	Steeped or rehydrated with boiled water, no simmering	Days 2+ when you have a little fuel
One-pot	A single pot, one cleanup	When fuel and water allow real cooking
Fuel-intensive	Long simmers (split peas, dry beans)	Only when fuel is plentiful
Evacuation	Eaten from the package, zero dishes, survives a hot car	Go-bags, car kits, shelters

The leftover rule for every recipe in this chapter

Without reliable refrigeration, cook and open **only what will be eaten this meal**. Anything perishable left at room temperature beyond 2 hours (1 hour when it's above 90 °F) belongs in the trash — "when in doubt, throw it out" (USDA). Single-serve packaging is your best tool for enforcing this.

Tuna Salad on Crackers

Serves 2 · 5 min

High-protein · Evacuation-ready · Low-water · Kid-friendly

Ingredients

- 2 pouches or cans tuna, drained
- 1/3 cup mayonnaise (shelf-stable jar)
- 1 tbsp relish (optional)
- 2 sleeves crackers

Preparation

Mix tuna, mayonnaise and relish in the pouch or one bowl. Spoon onto crackers just before eating so they stay crisp.

Subs: Canned chicken or salmon instead of tuna; mustard instead of mayonnaise.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Single-serve pouches avoid leftovers. If using a large can without refrigeration, eat the whole portion the same meal. Fish allergy: use chicken. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Chickpea Smash Sandwiches

Serves 2 · 8 min

High-protein · Budget · Kid-friendly

Ingredients

- 1 can (15 oz) chickpeas, drained and rinsed
- 2 tbsp mayonnaise or olive oil
- 1/2 tsp garlic powder
- 4 slices bread or 4 soft tortillas

Preparation

Mash chickpeas in a bowl with a sturdy spoon or cup bottom.

Stir in mayonnaise and garlic powder; season with salt and pepper.

Pile onto bread or roll into tortillas.

Subs: Canned white beans work the same; add relish or hot sauce for adults.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None (draining only)	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Rinsing cuts sodium but uses about 1 cup of water — skip the rinse if water is short and plan extra drinking water. Eat all filling the same meal if refrigeration is unavailable. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Peanut Butter and Raisin Crackers

Serves 2 · 3 min

Kid-friendly · Evacuation-ready · Low-water · Budget · Breakfast

Ingredients

- 24 crackers
- 6 tbsp peanut butter
- 4 tbsp raisins
- Honey (optional)

Preparation

Spread peanut butter on crackers.

Top with raisins and a drizzle of honey.

Subs: Any seed butter for peanut-free households; dried cranberries for raisins.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	0 — from package

Storage & safety: Peanut allergy: substitute sunflower seed butter and check all labels. Keeps indefinitely as a go-bag meal. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Mediterranean Chickpea Salad

Serves 2 · 8 min

High-protein · Budget

Ingredients

- 1 can (15 oz) chickpeas, drained
- 1/2 cup canned olives, drained and halved
- 1/2 cup sun-dried or canned tomatoes, drained
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tsp Italian seasoning

Preparation

Combine everything in one bowl.

Season with salt and pepper; toss gently.

Subs: Canned white beans or cannellini beans replace chickpeas; add canned artichokes if stocked.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None (draining only)	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: High-sodium combo — pair with extra drinking water. No leftovers without refrigeration. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

Salmon Salad on Crispbread

Serves 2 • 5 min

High-protein • Evacuation-ready

Ingredients

- 1 can (14.75 oz) salmon, drained
- 1/4 cup mayonnaise
- 1 tbsp lemon juice (bottled) or relish
- 12 crispbread or cracker rounds
- Black pepper

Preparation

Flake salmon, removing large bones if desired (they are edible).

Mix with mayonnaise and lemon juice.

Serve on crispbread with pepper.

Subs: Tuna or sardines; mustard instead of mayonnaise.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Fish allergy: swap for canned chicken. Choose single-serve cans to avoid leftovers. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Granola Breakfast Bowl

Serves 1 • 2 min

Breakfast • Kid-friendly • Evacuation-ready • Low-water

Ingredients

- 3/4 cup granola
- 1 cup shelf-stable milk (carton)
- 1/2 cup canned fruit, drained, or dried fruit

Preparation

Pour granola into a bowl or the empty carton.

Add milk and fruit; stir.

Subs: Cereal instead of granola; powdered milk mixed with safe water.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Single-serve milk cartons remove the open-container problem entirely. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

White Bean and Olive Salad

Serves 2 • 6 min

High-protein • Budget

Ingredients

- 2 cans (15 oz each) white beans, drained
- 1/3 cup canned olives, drained
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tsp Italian seasoning
- Crackers or bread to serve

Preparation

Stir beans, olives, oil and seasoning together.

Serve alongside crackers.

Subs: Chickpeas or kidney beans; red wine vinegar if stocked.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None (draining only)	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Rinse beans only if water budget allows. No leftovers without refrigeration. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Ham and Cheese Cracker Stack

Serves 2 • 5 min

Kid-friendly • Evacuation-ready • Low-water • High-protein

Ingredients

- 1 can (5 oz) ham or luncheon meat, sliced
- Shelf-stable cheese slices or cheese spread
- 24 crackers
- Mustard (optional)

Preparation

Layer meat and cheese on crackers.

Add mustard if desired.

Subs: Canned chicken with cheese spread; peanut butter replaces cheese for dairy-free.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	0 — from package

Storage & safety: Use single-can portions. High in sodium — plan extra water. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

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Black Bean and Corn Salsa Salad

Serves 3 · 7 min

Budget · High-protein

Ingredients

- 1 can (15 oz) black beans, drained
- 1 can (15 oz) corn, drained
- 1/2 cup salsa
- 1 tsp taco seasoning (optional)
- Tortilla chips or crackers

Preparation

Mix beans, corn and salsa in one bowl.

Season to taste; serve with chips.

Subs: Kidney beans or pinto beans; canned tomatoes with green chiles instead of salsa.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None (draining only)	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Filling and shelf-driven; sodium varies widely by salsa brand — check labels. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Peanut Butter Tortilla Roll-Ups

Serves 2 · 4 min

Kid-friendly · Breakfast · Evacuation-ready · Low-water · Budget

Ingredients

- 4 flour tortillas
- 6 tbsp peanut butter
- 4 tbsp honey or jam
- 1/2 cup raisins or trail mix (optional)

Preparation

Spread tortillas with peanut butter, then honey or jam.

Sprinkle with raisins, roll tightly and slice if desired.

Subs: Seed butter for nut-free; crackers instead of tortillas.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	0 — from package

Storage & safety: Excellent car-kit meal — survives heat better than most bars. Peanut allergy: seed butter. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Sardine Toast with Mustard

Serves 1 · 3 min

High-protein · Evacuation-ready · Low-water

Ingredients

- 1 tin sardines (in water or olive oil)
- 6 crackers or 2 slices crispbread
- Mustard or hot sauce
- Crushed red pepper (optional)

Preparation

Open tin, drain lightly if preferred.

Place sardines on crackers; finish with mustard.

Subs: Mackerel, tuna or smoked oysters; lemon juice instead of mustard.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	0 — from package

Storage & safety: Single-serve tins mean zero leftovers. Fish allergy: use canned chicken. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Pantry Antipasto Plate

Serves 2 · 6 min

Evacuation-ready · High-protein

Ingredients

- 1 cup crackers
- 1/2 cup canned olives, drained
- 2 oz jerky
- Shelf-stable cheese or cheese spread
- Canned pepperoncini or roasted red peppers, drained

Preparation

Arrange everything on one plate or board.

Serve crackers alongside.

Subs: Swap any element for what you stock: canned artichokes, dried fruit, nuts.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: A build-your-own plate children accept easily. Sodium is high across the plate — budget water. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

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Applesauce Granola Cups

Serves 2 · 3 min

Kid-friendly · Breakfast · Budget

Ingredients

- 2 single-serve cups applesauce
- 1/2 cup granola
- 2 tbsp peanut butter or seed butter
- Cinnamon

Preparation

Spoon applesauce into bowls.

Top with granola, a spoonful of peanut butter and cinnamon.

Subs: Canned fruit cups instead of applesauce; crushed cereal instead of granola.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Single-serve cups keep portions and leftovers under control. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Chicken Salad Wraps

Serves 2 · 6 min

High-protein · Evacuation-ready

Ingredients

- 1 can (12.5 oz) chicken, drained
- 1/4 cup mayonnaise
- 1 tbsp relish
- 1/4 tsp garlic powder
- 4 flour tortillas

Preparation

Mix chicken, mayonnaise, relish and garlic powder.

Spoon down the center of each tortilla and roll.

Subs: Tuna or salmon; mustard-based dressing if preferred.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Eat all filling the same meal without refrigeration. Use single-serve mayo packets when available. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Fruit Parfait Cups

Serves 2 · 3 min

Kid-friendly · Low-water · Budget

Ingredients

- 2 cups canned fruit (peaches, pears or mixed), drained
- 1/2 cup granola or crushed cereal
- 1/2 cup shelf-stable milk or yogurt-style pudding (shelf-stable)
- Cinnamon

Preparation

Layer fruit, granola and milk or pudding in cups.

Dust with cinnamon.

Subs: Dried fruit rehydrated in a splash of fruit juice; trail mix instead of granola.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Drain fruit into a cup and drink the juice — do not waste the water. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Overnight-Style Oats with Peanut Butter

Serves 1 · 5 min + soak

Breakfast · Budget

Ingredients

- 1/2 cup quick oats
- 3/4 cup safe water or shelf-stable milk
- 1 tbsp peanut butter
- 1 tbsp raisins or dried fruit
- Pinch of cinnamon

Preparation

Stir oats and water in a jar or bowl; cover.

Soak at least 30 minutes (overnight if cool enough per your judgment of conditions).

Top with peanut butter, raisins and cinnamon.

Subs: Granola eaten dry if soaking water is a concern; honey instead of fruit.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	3/4 cup per serving (safe, cold)	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Soaked grains without refrigeration should be eaten the same day and discarded if left more than 2 hours in warm conditions — when in doubt, throw it out. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

Pantry Snack Board for Kids

Serves 2 · 4 min

Kid-friendly · Evacuation-ready · Low-water

Ingredients

- 1 cup crackers
- 1/2 cup cereal
- 1/4 cup trail mix or dried fruit
- Peanut butter or seed butter for dipping
- 1 single-serve applesauce

Preparation

Arrange everything on one plate in sections.

Let children assemble their own bites.

Subs: Any combination of shelf snacks; cheese spread replaces peanut butter if needed.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Grazing boards help children eat when routines are disrupted. Check allergens on shared boards. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Bean Dip and Chips

Serves 3 · 6 min

Budget · High-protein · Kid-friendly

Ingredients

- 1 can (15 oz) refried beans or seasoned beans
- 1/4 cup salsa
- Tortilla chips
- Hot sauce (optional)

Preparation

Mash beans with salsa until dip-like.

Serve with chips.

Subs: Mashed canned black beans with taco seasoning; crackers instead of chips.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None (draining only)	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Open cans transfer to a clean covered container if refrigeration exists; without it, eat the full portion the same meal. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Trail Mix Energy Bowls

Serves 1 · 2 min

Evacuation-ready · Low-water · Budget

Ingredients

- 1/2 cup trail mix
- 1/4 cup granola
- 2 tbsp peanut butter
- 1 single-serve fruit cup or dried fruit

Preparation

Combine trail mix and granola.

Eat with spoonfuls of peanut butter and fruit on the side.

Subs: Any nuts, seeds, cereal and dried fruit you stock.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	0 — from package

Storage & safety: Dense calories with zero prep — a strong evacuation meal. Nut allergies: seeds only. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Cinnamon Cereal Cups

Serves 1 · 2 min

Kid-friendly · Breakfast · Evacuation-ready · Low-water

Ingredients

- 1 1/2 cups shelf-stable cereal
- 1 cup shelf-stable milk
- Cinnamon and sugar (optional)

Preparation

Pour cereal into a bowl or cup.

Add milk; dust with cinnamon.

Subs: Granola, oats eaten as cold-soak (see Overnight-Style Oats), or dry cereal as a snack.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Single-serve milk cartons are the cleanest format when dishes and water are limited. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

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Jerky, Nuts and Dried Fruit Plate

Serves 2 · 2 min

High-protein · Evacuation-ready · Low-water

Ingredients

- 2 oz beef or turkey jerky
- 1/2 cup nuts or seeds
- 1/3 cup dried fruit
- Crackers (optional)

Preparation

Arrange on a plate; no preparation.

Subs: Any shelf protein: meat sticks, canned fish, roasted chickpeas.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Jerky is sodium-heavy; pair each serving with drinking water. Vegetarian: use roasted chickpeas and seeds. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Sardine and White Bean Mash

Serves 2 · 5 min

High-protein · Budget

Ingredients

- 1 tin sardines
- 1 can (15 oz) white beans, drained
- 1 tbsp olive oil
- Black pepper and lemon juice (bottled, optional)

Preparation

Mash beans and sardines together with oil.

Season; serve on crackers or bread.

Subs: Tuna or salmon instead of sardines; canned chicken for fish-free.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
No-Cook	None (draining only)	No-cook	1

Storage & safety: Very high protein per dollar. Fish allergy: use chicken and beans. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

CHAPTER 6

Hot-Water and One-Pot Meals

Forty-eight hot meals built around the two cheapest capabilities in emergency cooking: boiling water and washing one pot.

Hot-water cooking: the fuel thriftiest method

Some foods only need to sit in boiling water — couscous, instant rice, instant potatoes, quick oats, ramen and small pasta in a good thermos. Bring water to a boil once, pour, cover, walk away.

Compared with simmering a pot for twenty minutes, this cuts fuel use dramatically, and it works on a single small canister stove or even over boiled water carried in a thermos.

One-pot meals are the next rung: everything happens in a single pot — pasta and sauce, rice and beans, soup from cans. One pot means one cleanup, which means the little water you spend washing dishes stays little.

The four rules of hot-water thrift

- **Cover the pot.** A lid shortens boil time and saves fuel on every single meal.
- **Cook short grains first.** Instant rice, couscous and quick oats before pasta; pasta before dry beans.
- **Use the package ratio.** Absorbed water is free dishwater — drained water is spent twice.
- **Batch only when safe.** Cook extra only if leftovers can be eaten within 2 hours, kept above 140 °F, or chilled below 40 °F — otherwise cook per meal.

Peanut Butter Oatmeal

Serves 1 • 5 min

Breakfast • Kid-friendly • Budget

- Ingredients**
 - 1/2 cup quick oats
 - 3/4–1 cup boiling water
 - 1 tbsp peanut butter
 - 1 tbsp brown sugar or honey
 - Pinch of salt
- Preparation**

Pour boiling water over oats; cover 3 minutes.

Stir in peanut butter, sweetener and salt.

Subs: Powdered milk stirred in for creaminess; raisins or dried fruit instead of sugar.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 1 cup per serving (absorbed)	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: Follow your oat package's ratio — brands vary. Absorbed water means no dirty dishwater. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Couscous with Chicken and Peas

Serves 2 • 10 min

High-protein • Low-water

- Ingredients**
 - 1 cup couscous
 - 1 1/4 cups boiling water or broth (bouillon + water)
 - 1 can (12.5 oz) chicken, drained
 - 1/2 cup canned peas, drained
 - 1 tbsp olive oil
 - Italian seasoning
- Preparation**

Stir couscous into boiling water or broth; cover 5 minutes.

Fluff, then fold in chicken, peas and oil.

Season with Italian seasoning, salt and pepper.

Subs: Canned tuna or beans instead of chicken; dehydrated vegetables rehydrated in the same water.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 1 1/4 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: Couscous is one of the most fuel-efficient grains — it steeps rather than boils. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Upgraded Ramen Bowl

Serves 1 • 8 min

Budget • Kid-friendly

- Ingredients**
 - 1 packet ramen
 - 1 tbsp powdered egg (rehydrated per label) or shelf-stable egg
 - 2 tbsp dehydrated mixed vegetables
 - Half the seasoning packet, to taste
- Preparation**

Pour boiling water over noodles and dehydrated vegetables in a heat-safe bowl; cover 4 minutes.

Stir in rehydrated egg and half the seasoning packet.

Subs: Add canned chicken for protein; use only part of the seasoning packet to cut sodium.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 2 cups (partly absorbed)	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: Ramen seasoning packets are very high in sodium — using half keeps flavor while cutting salt. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Instant Mash and Gravy Chicken Bowl

Serves 2 • 8 min

Kid-friendly • High-protein • Comfort food

- Ingredients**
 - 2 cups instant mashed potato flakes
 - 1 1/2 cups hot water or milk (shelf-stable)
 - 1 jar or packet gravy mix (prepared per label)
 - 1 can (12.5 oz) chicken, drained
 - Black pepper
- Preparation**

Stir potato flakes into hot water until smooth.

Heat or mix gravy per package; fold in chicken.

Spoon gravy and chicken over the mash.

Subs: Canned ham or turkey instead of chicken; cream-style canned soup as gravy.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 1 3/4 cups total (absorbed)	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: A high-acceptance comfort meal for kids and older adults with lower chewing needs. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

Thermos Tomato Pasta

Serves 1 · 15 min

Evacuation-ready · Kid-friendly

Ingredients

- 1/2 cup small pasta (orzo, stars or broken spaghetti)
- 1 1/2 cups boiling water
- 1/3 cup tomato sauce (from a jar or single-serve pouch)
- Italian seasoning, salt

Preparation

Preheat thermos with boiling water; empty.

Add pasta and fresh boiling water; seal 10–12 minutes.

Stir in tomato sauce and seasonings.

Subs: Couscous or instant rice if pasta won't soften in your thermos; add tuna or chicken.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 2 cups (mostly absorbed)	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: Test your thermos once at home — cook times vary by brand. Eat within 2 hours of cooking if it cools below 140 degrees F. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Instant Rice and Black Beans

Serves 2 · 10 min

Budget · High-protein

Ingredients

- 1 cup instant rice
- 1 1/2 cups boiling water or broth
- 1 can (15 oz) black beans, drained
- 1/2 cup salsa
- Taco seasoning

Preparation

Combine rice and boiling water; cover 5 minutes.

Stir in beans and salsa; cover 2–3 minutes more to warm through.

Season with taco seasoning.

Subs: Canned pinto beans or chickpeas; add shelf-stable cheese if stocked.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 1 1/2 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: Instant rice instead of regular rice cuts fuel use by about two thirds. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Creamy Tomato Soup with Pasta

Serves 2 · 12 min

Kid-friendly · Comfort food · Budget

Ingredients

- 1 can (10.75 oz) condensed tomato soup
- 1 soup can of hot water
- 1/2 cup small pasta
- 1/2 cup shelf-stable milk
- Crackers to serve

Preparation

Heat soup and water together to a simmer in one pot.

Add pasta; cook per package (about 8–9 minutes) until tender.

Stir in milk off the heat; serve with crackers.

Subs: Any condensed soup; rice instead of pasta.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 3 cups total	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: Condensed soups pull double duty as sauce and broth — stock several varieties. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Breakfast Couscous with Cinnamon

Serves 2 · 7 min

Breakfast · Low-water

Ingredients

- 1 cup couscous
- 1 1/4 cups boiling water or shelf-stable milk
- 2 tbsp brown sugar or honey
- 1/2 tsp cinnamon
- 2 tbsp dried fruit
- 2 tbsp nuts or seeds

Preparation

Stir couscous into boiling liquid; cover 5 minutes.

Fluff; stir in sweetener, cinnamon and fruit; top with nuts.

Subs: Instant oats instead of couscous; maple syrup instead of honey.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 1 1/4 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: Honey should not be given to children under 1 year — see pediatric guidance. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

Miso-Style Noodle Cup

Serves 1 • 7 min

Evacuation-ready • Budget

- Ingredients**
 - 1 packet ramen or rice noodles
 - 1 tsp bouillon (chicken, vegetable or beef)
 - 2 tbsp dehydrated vegetables
 - 1 tsp soy sauce
 - 1 tsp peanut butter (optional, for richness)
- Preparation**

Combine noodles, bouillon and vegetables in a bowl or cup.

Pour boiling water over; cover 4–5 minutes.

Finish with soy sauce and peanut butter.

Subs: Any instant noodle; skip peanut butter for nut-free households.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 1 3/4 cups	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: Only one container to eat from — a strong evacuation meal when paired with bottled water. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Red Lentil Stew

Serves 2 • 20 min

High-protein • Budget

- Ingredients**
 - 1/2 cup red lentils, rinsed
 - 2 cups water or broth
 - 1/2 tsp bouillon
 - 1/4 cup canned diced tomatoes
 - 1/2 tsp curry powder
 - Salt
- Preparation**

Combine lentils, water, bouillon, tomatoes and curry in one pot.

Simmer covered 15–18 minutes, stirring once, until lentils are soft.

Season with salt.

Subs: Split peas (longer cook time); add instant rice to stretch.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 2 1/2 cups (mostly absorbed)	Low	1

Storage & safety: Red lentils cook far faster than beans — the best legume for low-fuel kitchens. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Chicken Congee with Instant Rice

Serves 2 • 12 min

High-protein • Comfort food

- Ingredients**
 - 1/2 cup instant rice
 - 3 cups hot water or broth
 - 1 can (12.5 oz) chicken, drained
 - 1 tsp bouillon
 - 1 tsp soy sauce
 - Sliced jerky or crushed crackers to top
- Preparation**

Simmer rice in water with bouillon 8–10 minutes until porridge-thick.

Stir in chicken and soy sauce.

Top as desired.

Subs: Canned fish instead of chicken; ginger powder if stocked.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 3 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: Gentle on digestion — useful for households with older adults or anyone feeling unwell. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Tabbouleh-Style Couscous Salad

Serves 2 • 12 min

Low-water

- Ingredients**
 - 1 cup couscous
 - 1 1/4 cups boiling water
 - 1/2 cup canned tomatoes, drained and chopped
 - 1/4 cup canned olives, drained
 - 2 tbsp olive oil
 - 1 tbsp lemon juice (bottled)
 - Dried parsley or mint
- Preparation**

Steep couscous in boiling water 5 minutes; fluff and let cool slightly.

Toss with tomatoes, olives, oil, lemon juice and herbs.

Serve warm or at room temperature.

Subs: Cucumber-style flavor from pickle relish; chickpeas for extra protein.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 1 1/4 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: Tastes good without refrigeration-level chilling, which makes it practical on day two or three of an outage. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

Mac and Cheese Cup

Serves 1 • 12 min

Kid-friendly • Comfort food • Budget

Ingredients

Preparation

- 1/2 cup elbow macaroni
- 2 tbsp cheese powder (from a mac-and-cheese box or bulk)
- 2 tbsp shelf-stable milk
- 1 tsp butter powder or oil

Boil macaroni in one pot per package directions; drain carefully, reserving a splash of water.

Off heat, stir in cheese powder, milk and butter powder.

Subs: Tuna or canned chicken stirred in; hot sauce for adults.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 2 cups (pasta absorbed)	Low	1

Storage & safety: Save the cheese powder from boxed mac-and-cheese purchases — it keeps well and works in soups too. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Chili Over Instant Potatoes

Serves 2 • 10 min

High-protein • Comfort food • Kid-friendly

Ingredients

Preparation

- 1 1/2 cups instant potato flakes
- 1 1/4 cups hot water
- 1 can (15 oz) chili with beans
- Shelf-stable cheese or crackers to top

Heat chili in a pot or can-safe water bath until hot.

Stir potato flakes into hot water.

Spoon chili over the mash; top as desired.

Subs: Canned stew over mash; black beans with salsa instead of chili.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 1 1/2 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: Chili cans vary widely in sodium — compare labels before stocking several. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Thai-Style Peanut Noodles

Serves 2 • 10 min

Kid-friendly • High-protein

Ingredients

Preparation

- 2 packets ramen (discard or halve seasoning)
- 2 tbsp peanut butter
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp honey
- 1/4 tsp garlic powder
- 2 tbsp dehydrated vegetables

Cook noodles per package; drain, reserving 2–3 tablespoons of water.

Whisk peanut butter, soy sauce, honey, garlic powder and reserved water into a sauce.

Toss noodles with sauce and vegetables.

Subs: Sunflower seed butter for nut-free; hot sauce for adults.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 3 cups (mostly absorbed)	Low	1

Storage & safety: Peanut allergy: seed butter version only. Very high kid-acceptance. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Cheddar Potato Soup

Serves 2 • 10 min

Comfort food • Kid-friendly

Ingredients

Preparation

- 1 1/2 cups instant potato flakes
- 2 cups hot water or shelf-stable milk
- Shelf-stable cheese sauce (single-serve) or cheese powder
- 1/2 cup canned corn
- Crushed crackers to top

Whisk potato flakes into hot liquid.

Stir in cheese and corn; warm through.

Top with crushed crackers.

Subs: Broccoli pieces (dehydrated) instead of corn; ham bits from a canned ham.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 2 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: Smooth texture suits older adults; adjust thickness with extra hot water. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

Cinnamon Raisin Oatmeal

Serves 2 · 6 min

Breakfast · Kid-friendly · Budget

Ingredients

- 1 cup quick oats
- 1 3/4 cups boiling water
- 3 tbsp powdered milk (dry-stirred)
- 1/4 cup raisins
- 1 tbsp brown sugar
- 1/2 tsp cinnamon

Preparation

Combine oats and boiling water; cover 3 minutes.

Stir in powdered milk, raisins, sugar and cinnamon.

Subs: Dried cranberries or chopped dried apples; honey instead of sugar.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 1 3/4 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: Powdered milk stirred in dry prevents clumps. Check your oats' package ratio. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Savory Oats with Egg and Bouillon

Serves 1 · 8 min

Breakfast · High-protein

Ingredients

- 1/2 cup quick oats
- 1 1/4 cups hot water
- 1 tsp bouillon
- 2 tbsp powdered egg (rehydrated per label)
- Hot sauce or black pepper

Preparation

Cook oats in water with bouillon 3 minutes.

Stir in rehydrated egg; cook 1–2 minutes more.

Finish with hot sauce or pepper.

Subs: Jerky bits or canned chicken stirred in; soy sauce instead of bouillon.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 1 1/4 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1

Storage & safety: Egg allergy: omit egg and add canned chicken instead. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Ham and Potato Soup

Serves 2 · 12 min

High-protein · Comfort food

Ingredients

- 1 1/2 cups instant potato flakes
- 2 cups hot water
- 1/2 cup canned ham, diced
- 1/2 cup shelf-stable milk
- Black pepper, dried chives (optional)

Preparation

Warm ham in the pot 1–2 minutes.

Add water and bring to a simmer; whisk in potato flakes.

Stir in milk; season.

Subs: Canned chicken instead of ham; dehydrated vegetables added with the water.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 2 cups (absorbed)	Low	1

Storage & safety: Canned ham is already cooked — you are warming it, not cooking it, which saves fuel. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Dehydrated Vegetable Soup

Serves 2 · 15 min

Budget · Low-water

Ingredients

- 1/2 cup dehydrated mixed vegetables
- 3 cups water
- 1 tbsp bouillon
- 1/2 cup instant rice
- Italian seasoning

Preparation

Combine vegetables, water and bouillon; simmer 8 minutes.

Stir in rice; simmer 5 minutes more.

Season to taste.

Subs: Any dehydrated or freeze-dried vegetables; add canned beans for protein.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 3 cups	Low	1

Storage & safety: A good use for garden surplus or bulk dehydrated vegetables bought on sale. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

Instant Polenta with Tomato Sauce

Serves 2 · 10 min

Comfort food · Budget

Ingredients

- 1/2 cup instant polenta
- 2 cups water
- 1 cup tomato sauce
- Italian seasoning
- Shelf-stable cheese (optional)

Preparation

Whisk polenta into simmering water; stir 3–5 minutes until thick.

Warm tomato sauce in the same pot alongside or after.

Sauce over polenta; top with cheese if stocked.

Subs: Instant mashed potatoes instead of polenta; canned chili instead of tomato sauce.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 2 cups (absorbed)	Low	1

Storage & safety: Stir constantly to avoid scorching on a camp stove. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Bulgur Pilaf with Chickpeas

Serves 2 · 18 min

High-protein · Budget

Ingredients

- 3/4 cup bulgur
- 1 3/4 cups boiling water or broth
- 1 can (15 oz) chickpeas, drained
- 1 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tsp bouillon
- Onion powder, black pepper

Preparation

Pour boiling broth over bulgur; cover 10–12 minutes.

Fluff; fold in chickpeas, oil and seasonings.

Rest 2 minutes before serving.

Subs: Couscous (5-minute version) when fuel is tight; lentils instead of chickpeas.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
Hot-Water	About 1 3/4 cups (absorbed)	Low	1

Storage & safety: Bulgur is a whole grain with more fiber than white rice — vary your grains to vary your fiber. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

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Canned food is already cooked

Canned meats, beans, soups and vegetables are fully cooked during canning. You are heating them, not cooking them — which is why most one-pot meals here finish in 25 minutes or less. Do not cook from cans over open flame unless the label says the can is safe for that; transfer to a pot instead.

Chili Mac

Serves 4 · 25 min

Kid-friendly · Comfort food · High-protein

Ingredients

- 8 oz elbow macaroni
- 1 can (15 oz) chili with beans
- 1 cup tomato sauce
- 1/2 cup water
- Shelf-stable cheese to top

Preparation

Boil macaroni in one pot per package; drain, reserving 1/2 cup water.

Return pasta to pot; stir in chili, tomato sauce and splashes of reserved water.

Warm through; top with cheese.

Subs: Any short pasta; vegetarian chili; add canned corn.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 3 cups	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Family favorite — taste-test it once before an emergency to confirm your household's rating. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Pantry Three-Bean Chili

Serves 4 · 25 min

High-protein · Budget · Comfort food

Ingredients

- 2 cans (15 oz each) beans, any mix, drained
- 1 can (14.5 oz) diced tomatoes
- 1 can (8 oz) tomato sauce
- 1 packet chili or taco seasoning
- 1/2 cup water

Preparation

Combine everything in one pot.

Simmer 15–20 minutes, stirring occasionally.

Season to taste.

Subs: Add canned corn, canned chicken or jerky pieces; hot sauce for adults.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 1 cup	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Rinsing beans reduces sodium about 40 percent per USDA-style label math but costs water — your call. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Red Beans and Rice

Serves 4 · 30 min

Budget · High-protein

Ingredients

- 1 1/2 cups instant rice
- 1 can (15 oz) red or kidney beans, drained
- 1 can (14.5 oz) diced tomatoes
- 1 tsp bouillon
- 1 tsp Cajun or chili seasoning
- 1 1/2 cups water

Preparation

Combine tomatoes, beans, bouillon, seasoning and water; simmer 10 minutes.

Stir in rice; cover and remove from heat 5–10 minutes.

Fluff and serve.

Subs: Canned ham or sausage-style shelf meat stirred in; black beans instead of red.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 2 1/2 cups	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Using instant rice here keeps a classic within low-fuel reach. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Chicken Noodle Soup from Cans

Serves 4 · 25 min

Kid-friendly · Comfort food · High-protein

Ingredients

- 2 cans (12.5 oz each) chicken, drained
- 4 cups water plus 2 cups broth (bouillon)
- 2 cups egg noodles
- 1 cup canned mixed vegetables, drained
- Salt, pepper, dried parsley

Preparation

Bring water and broth to a boil.

Add noodles; cook per package (about 7 minutes).

Add chicken and vegetables; simmer 3–5 minutes; season.

Subs: Rice instead of noodles; canned turkey or ham.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 6 cups	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: The single most requested comfort meal during outages — prioritize its ingredients in your list. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

Pasta with Marinara

Serves 4 · 20 min

Kid-friendly · Budget · Comfort food

Ingredients

- 12 oz spaghetti or penne
- 1 jar (24 oz) marinara sauce
- Italian seasoning
- Shelf-stable cheese (optional)
- Crackers or bread to serve

Preparation

Boil pasta per package; drain.

Warm sauce in the same pot.

Toss together; season.

Subs: Canned tomato sauce plus seasoning if no jar sauce; add canned chicken or tuna.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 8 cups for boiling	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Boiling pasta uses the most water of any method here — reuse the pot water for sanitation, not drinking, if you must. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Tuna Noodle Skillet

Serves 3 · 20 min

High-protein · Budget

Ingredients

- 8 oz egg noodles
- 2 cans tuna, drained
- 1 can (10.75 oz) cream-style soup
- 1/2 cup shelf-stable milk
- Crushed crackers to top

Preparation

Boil noodles; drain.

Stir soup, milk and tuna into the pot; warm gently.

Top with crushed crackers.

Subs: Canned chicken instead of tuna; mushroom or celery soup varieties.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 6 cups for boiling	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Fish allergy: swap to chicken. A Depression-era budget meal that still works. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Hearty Lentil Soup

Serves 4 · 35 min

Budget · High-protein

Ingredients

- 1 cup brown or green lentils, rinsed
- 6 cups water or broth
- 1 tbsp bouillon
- 1 can (14.5 oz) diced tomatoes
- 1 tsp Italian seasoning
- Salt and pepper

Preparation

Combine everything in one pot.

Simmer covered 25–30 minutes until lentils are tender.

Season; mash slightly if a thicker soup is wanted.

Subs: Canned carrots or corn added near the end; ham pieces for meat-eaters.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 6 cups	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Dry lentils are among the cheapest proteins per serving you can stock. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Split Pea Soup

Serves 4 · 45 min

Budget · High-protein

Ingredients

- 1 cup split peas, rinsed
- 7 cups water or broth
- 1 tbsp bouillon
- 1/2 cup canned ham, diced
- Salt, pepper, onion powder

Preparation

Combine peas, water, bouillon and ham in one pot.

Simmer 35–45 minutes, stirring occasionally, until peas break down.

Season.

Subs: Vegetarian version with smoked paprika instead of ham.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 7 cups	High	1

Storage & safety: Higher fuel meal — cook it when you have fuel to spare, or use the thermos method: boil 10 minutes, then rest in an insulated pot 1 hour. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

Black Bean Soup with Salsa

Serves 4 · 20 min

Budget · High-protein · Kid-friendly

Ingredients

- 2 cans (15 oz each) black beans, drained
- 1 cup salsa
- 1 cup water or broth
- 1 tsp cumin or taco seasoning
- Crackers or rice to serve

Preparation

Combine everything in one pot.

Simmer 10–15 minutes.

Mash lightly for a creamy texture.

Subs: Pinto beans; add corn; hot sauce for adults.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 1 cup	Low	1

Storage & safety: One of the fastest hot meals from cans — good for day one of any outage. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Chicken and Rice Skillet

Serves 4 · 25 min

High-protein · Comfort food

Ingredients

- 1 1/2 cups instant rice
- 1 can (12.5 oz) chicken, drained
- 1 can (10.75 oz) cream-style soup
- 1 cup water
- 1/2 cup dehydrated vegetables

Preparation

Combine soup, water and vegetables; simmer 5 minutes.

Stir in rice and chicken; cover off heat 5–10 minutes.

Fluff and serve.

Subs: Canned ham or tuna; tomato soup instead of cream soup.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 2 cups	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: A rice-casserole staple rebuilt for one pot and shelf ingredients. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Vegetable Beef-Style Soup

Serves 4 · 30 min

High-protein · Comfort food

Ingredients

- 2 cups water plus 5 cups broth (bouillon)
- 2 cans mixed vegetables, drained
- 1 can (15 oz) kidney beans, drained
- 1 can (14.5 oz) diced tomatoes
- 1/2 cup canned beef, ham or stew meat (optional)
- Salt, pepper, Italian seasoning

Preparation

Bring broth and tomatoes to a simmer.

Add vegetables, beans and meat.

Simmer 15 minutes; season.

Subs: Any canned vegetables; add pasta or rice for heartiness.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 7 cups	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Flexible template: swap in whatever canned vegetables you overstocked. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Mac and Cheese with Broccoli

Serves 4 · 25 min

Kid-friendly · Comfort food

Ingredients

- 12 oz elbow macaroni
- 1/2 cup dehydrated broccoli
- 2 boxes mac and cheese (cheese packets) or 1/2 cup cheese powder
- 1/2 cup shelf-stable milk
- 2 tbsp butter powder or oil

Preparation

Boil macaroni with broccoli in the last 3 minutes; drain.

Return to pot; stir in cheese, milk and butter powder.

Warm gently and serve.

Subs: Dehydrated peas or green beans; canned chicken stirred in.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 8 cups for boiling	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Boiling water is the main cost — batch this meal when fuel and water allow. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

Jambalaya-Style Rice

Serves 4 · 30 min

High-protein · Comfort food

Ingredients

- 1 1/2 cups instant rice
- 1 can (14.5 oz) diced tomatoes
- 1/2 cup canned ham, diced
- 1/2 cup canned corn, drained
- 1 tsp Cajun seasoning
- 3/4 cup water

Preparation

Combine tomatoes, ham, corn, seasoning and water; simmer 8 minutes.

Stir in rice; cover off heat 5–10 minutes.

Fluff; adjust seasoning.

Subs: Canned shrimp-style substitutes are rare — canned chicken works well.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 2 1/4 cups	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Cajun seasoning carries the flavor; mild version for kids with just salt and onion powder. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Tex-Mex Rice Bowls

Serves 4 · 25 min

Kid-friendly · High-protein · Budget

Ingredients

- 1 1/2 cups instant rice
- 1 can (15 oz) black or pinto beans, drained
- 1 cup salsa
- 1 tsp taco seasoning
- 1 cup water
- Shelf-stable cheese and crackers to top

Preparation

Combine beans, salsa, seasoning and water; simmer 8 minutes.

Stir in rice; cover off heat 5–10 minutes.

Serve with toppings on the side.

Subs: Corn added; canned chicken for extra protein; build-your-own format for picky eaters.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 2 cups	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Build-your-own bowls let each person control spice level. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Creamy Chicken and Noodles

Serves 4 · 25 min

Comfort food · High-protein

Ingredients

- 8 oz egg noodles
- 1 can (12.5 oz) chicken, drained
- 1 can (10.75 oz) cream-style soup
- 3/4 cup shelf-stable milk
- Black pepper, dried parsley

Preparation

Boil noodles; drain.

Stir soup, milk, chicken and seasonings into the pot.

Warm through gently.

Subs: Rice instead of noodles; canned ham or turkey.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 6 cups for boiling	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Freezes beautifully as a normal-week meal too — part of the store-what-you-eat rotation. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Minestrone-Style Pantry Soup

Serves 4 · 30 min

Budget

Ingredients

- 5 cups broth (bouillon + water)
- 1 can (14.5 oz) diced tomatoes
- 1 can (15 oz) white beans, drained
- 1/2 cup small pasta
- 1 cup canned mixed vegetables, drained
- Italian seasoning

Preparation

Bring broth and tomatoes to a simmer.

Add pasta and vegetables; cook per pasta package.

Add beans last to warm; season.

Subs: Rice instead of pasta; any beans; add shelf-stable pesto if stocked.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 6 cups	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: A clean template for using up random cans — see the meal formula in Chapter 8. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

Salmon Rice Pilaf

Serves 3 • 25 min

High-protein

Ingredients

- 1 cup instant rice
- 1 can (14.75 oz) salmon, drained
- 1 can (10.75 oz) condensed soup (chicken or mushroom)
- 1 cup water
- 1/4 cup dehydrated vegetables
- Black pepper, dried dill (optional)

Preparation

Combine soup, water and vegetables; simmer 5 minutes.

Stir in rice and salmon; cover off heat 5–10 minutes.

Fluff; season.

Subs: Canned tuna or chicken instead of salmon.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 2 cups	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Fish allergy: swap proteins. Salmon bones are edible and calcium-rich — remove if preferred. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Curried Rice and Lentils

Serves 4 • 30 min

High-protein • Budget

Ingredients

- 1/2 cup red lentils, rinsed
- 1 cup instant rice
- 2 1/2 cups water or broth
- 1 tbsp bouillon
- 1–2 tsp curry powder
- 1/2 cup canned coconut milk (optional)
- Salt

Preparation

Simmer lentils in water with bouillon and curry 12–15 minutes.

Stir in rice and coconut milk; cover off heat 5 minutes.

Season.

Subs: Chili powder or taco seasoning instead of curry; skip coconut milk if not stocked.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 3 cups	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Mild for kids by cutting curry powder to 1/2 teaspoon; hot sauce at the table for adults. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Tomato-Tuna Rice Skillet

Serves 3 • 25 min

High-protein • Budget

Ingredients

- 1 cup instant rice
- 1 can (14.5 oz) diced tomatoes
- 2 cans tuna, drained
- 1/2 cup water
- 1 tsp Italian seasoning
- Shelf-stable cheese (optional)

Preparation

Simmer tomatoes, water and seasoning 5 minutes.

Stir in rice; cover off heat 5 minutes.

Fold in tuna; top with cheese if stocked.

Subs: Canned chicken instead of tuna; olives added for adults.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 2 cups	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Fish allergy: use chicken. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Ham and Split Pea Stew

Serves 4 • 45 min

High-protein

Ingredients

- 1 cup split peas, rinsed
- 6 cups water or broth
- 3/4 cup canned ham, diced
- 1 tsp bouillon
- Onion powder, black pepper

Preparation

Combine peas, water, bouillon and seasonings.

Simmer 30 minutes; add ham for the final 10 minutes.

Simmer until thick; season.

Subs: Lentils cut cook time roughly in half.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 6 cups	High	1

Storage & safety: Plan this for a day when fuel is plentiful, or finish it with the insulated-pot method. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

Alfredo-Style Pasta

Serves 3 · 25 min

Kid-friendly · Comfort food

Ingredients

- 8 oz fettuccine or spaghetti
- 1 cup shelf-stable milk
- 3 tbsp shelf-stable cheese sauce or cheese powder
- 1 tbsp butter powder or oil
- Black pepper, garlic powder

Preparation

Boil pasta; drain, reserving 1/4 cup water.

Warm milk, cheese and butter powder in the pot.

Toss pasta with sauce, loosening with reserved water.

Subs: Canned chicken added; olive-oil-and-garlic version if dairy-free.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 6 cups for boiling	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Dairy-free: olive oil, garlic powder and a splash of pasta water make a light aglio-e-olio instead.

Nutrition: check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Spanish Rice with Black Beans

Serves 4 · 25 min

Budget · High-protein

Ingredients

- 1 1/2 cups instant rice
- 1 can (14.5 oz) diced tomatoes with green chiles
- 1 can (15 oz) black beans, drained
- 1 tsp cumin
- 3/4 cup water
- Hot sauce (optional)

Preparation

Combine tomatoes, beans, cumin and water; simmer 8 minutes.

Stir in rice; cover off heat 5–10 minutes.

Fluff; serve with hot sauce.

Subs: Corn stirred in; mild tomatoes for kids.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 2 cups	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: One of the cheapest dinners on this list per serving. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Chili Potato Skillet

Serves 3 · 15 min

Kid-friendly · High-protein · Comfort food

Ingredients

- 2 cups instant potato flakes
- 1 1/4 cups hot water
- 1 can (15 oz) chili
- Shelf-stable cheese or crackers

Preparation

Warm chili in the pot.

Fold potato flakes into hot water alongside or in the same pot off heat.

Layer mash and chili; top.

Subs: Canned stew instead of chili; corn on the side.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 1 1/4 cups	Low	1

Storage & safety: Under 15 minutes start to finish — a strong first-hot-meal after an outage. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Pancakes from the Pantry

Serves 3 · 20 min

Breakfast · Kid-friendly · Comfort food

Ingredients

- 2 cups complete pancake mix (water-only type)
- 1 1/2 cups water (per mix label)
- 2 tbsp oil
- Syrup, honey or jam to serve

Preparation

Stir mix and water just until combined — lumps are fine.

Heat oil in a skillet over medium heat.

Pour 1/4-cup rounds; flip when bubbles form; cook until golden.

Subs: Add peanut butter on top for protein; mashed canned fruit as a topping.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 1 1/2 cups	Moderate	2

Storage & safety: Choose 'complete' or 'just add water' mixes for emergencies. Skillet is the only true cooking surface needed. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

One-Pot Rice and Chicken Soup

Serves 4 • 30 min

High-protein • Comfort food

Ingredients

- 6 cups broth (bouillon + water)
- 3/4 cup white rice
- 1 can (12.5 oz) chicken, drained
- 1 cup canned mixed vegetables, drained
- Salt, pepper, dried parsley

Preparation

Bring broth to a simmer; add rice. Simmer covered 15–18 minutes until rice is tender.

Add chicken and vegetables; simmer 5 minutes; season.

Subs: Noodles instead of rice (add later, cook per package).

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 7 cups	Moderate	1

Storage & safety: Plain white rice stores longer than brown — for soup storage, white is the practical choice. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Bean and Cheese-Style Bowls

Serves 4 • 20 min

Kid-friendly • High-protein • Budget

Ingredients

- 2 cans (15 oz each) pinto or black beans, drained
- 1 cup salsa
- 1 tsp taco seasoning
- 1/2 cup water
- Shelf-stable cheese sauce to top
- Crackers or instant rice as base

Preparation

Warm beans with salsa, seasoning and water 10 minutes. Mash lightly.

Serve over crackers or instant rice with cheese sauce on top.

Subs: Corn added; mild salsa for kids; hot sauce for adults.

METHOD	WATER	FUEL	DISHES
One-Pot	About 1 cup	Low	1

Storage & safety: The bean-and-cheese comfort bowl from the familiar-foods list, built entirely shelf-stable. **Nutrition:** check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

All recipes use shelf-stable ingredients. Approximate water values follow typical package directions — verify on your labels.

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CHAPTER 7

The 30-Day Menu System

What to eat first, what to save, and a month of menus your family has already tasted — plus the power-outage timeline that protects your refrigerator food.

The chronological plan: what to eat, in order

Power-outage eating order (USDA food-safety guidance)

Phase	Eat / do	Avoid
First hours	Keep fridge and freezer doors closed — note the outage time. Eat ready-to-eat pantry foods. Perishables first only if the outage looks brief: the closed fridge keeps food safe up to 4 hours; a full freezer about 48 hours, half-full about 24.	Opening doors "to check." Cooking big meals while you still have fridge food to use.
First 24 h	Shift to no-cook pantry meals. Use thawing freezer items next if they are still cold (40 °F or below or with ice crystals). Start tracking water by marking jugs. Save fuel.	Using the oven "to heat the house." Wasting boiling water on drains.
Days 2–3	Introduce hot-water and one-pot meals. Discard fridge perishables that passed the 4-hour mark above 40 °F (see Chapter 9 table). Manage sanitation: hand sanitizer, disposable plates, outdoor dishwasher.	Tasting questionable food to test it. Saving opened leftovers without cold control.
Days 4–7	Rotate into the fuller pantry menu below. Preserve water and fuel with low-water recipes. Review inventory and note what your household actually ate.	Letting morale slide — schedule a comfort meal and a treat day.
Beyond a week	Run the 30-day menu grid; recalculate water and fuel weekly; adjust portions to appetite; plan replenishment runs when stores reopen.	Sticking to a menu your family is rejecting — swap meals, keep calories.

Never gamble with the fridge

Do not assume food is fine because it "looks okay." Pathogens do not change taste, smell or appearance — verify with an appliance thermometer and follow the keep/discard table in Chapter 9. When in doubt, throw it out.

The 30-day menu grid

Four weekly templates that repeat with swaps. Every entry names a recipe in this book or a simple assembly from your layers. Portions scale to your household; breakfasts and snacks pull from Layers 1–2.

Week 1 menu template

Day	Breakfast	Lunch (no-cook)	Dinner (hot)
Mon	Peanut Butter Oatmeal	Tuna Salad on Crackers	Chili Mac
Tue	Cinnamon Raisin Oatmeal	Chickpea Smash Sandwiches	Couscous with Chicken and Peas
Wed	Breakfast Couscous with Cinnamon	Salmon Salad on Crispbread	Chicken Noodle Soup from Cans
Thu	Overnight-Style Oats with Peanut Butter	Black Bean and Corn Salsa Salad	Instant Rice and Black Beans
Fri	Applesauce Granola Cups	Pantry Antipasto Plate	Black Bean Soup with Salsa
Sat	Granola Breakfast Bowl	Chicken Salad Wraps	Mac and Cheese Cup
Sun	Cinnamon Cereal Cups	Bean Dip and Chips	Pantry Three-Bean Chili

Week 2 menu template

Day	Breakfast	Lunch (no-cook)	Dinner (hot)
Mon	Savory Oats with Egg and Bouillon	Jerky, Nuts and Dried Fruit Plate	Creamy Tomato Soup with Pasta
Tue	Peanut Butter and Raisin Crackers	Mediterranean Chickpea Salad	Minestrone-Style Pantry Soup
Wed	Peanut Butter Oatmeal	White Bean and Olive Salad	Red Lentil Stew
Thu	Cinnamon Raisin Oatmeal	Sardine Toast with Mustard	Chili Potato Skillet
Fri	Breakfast Couscous with Cinnamon	Sardine and White Bean Mash	Thai-Style Peanut Noodles
Sat	Overnight-Style Oats with Peanut Butter	Ham and Cheese Cracker Stack	Curried Rice and Lentils
Sun	Applesauce Granola Cups	Fruit Parfait Cups	Instant Mash and Gravy Chicken Bowl

Week 3 menu template

Day	Breakfast	Lunch (no-cook)	Dinner (hot)
Mon	Cinnamon Cereal Cups	Pantry Snack Board for Kids	Spanish Rice with Black Beans
Tue	Pancakes from the Pantry	Trail Mix Energy Bowls	Tabbouleh-Style Couscous Salad
Wed	Savory Oats with Egg and Bouillon	Peanut Butter Tortilla Roll-Ups	Hearty Lentil Soup
Thu	Peanut Butter and Raisin Crackers	Applesauce Granola Cups	Cheddar Potato Soup
Fri	Peanut Butter Oatmeal	Peanut Butter and Raisin Crackers	Jambalaya-Style Rice
Sat	Cinnamon Raisin Oatmeal	Granola Breakfast Bowl	Chicken Congee with Instant Rice
Sun	Breakfast Couscous with Cinnamon	Overnight-Style Oats with Peanut Butter	Bean and Cheese-Style Bowls

Week 4 menu template

Day	Breakfast	Lunch (no-cook)	Dinner (hot)
Mon	Applesauce Granola Cups	Cinnamon Cereal Cups	Dehydrated Vegetable Soup
Tue	Granola Breakfast Bowl	Pantry Antipasto Plate	Chili Mac
Wed	Cinnamon Cereal Cups	Tuna Salad on Crackers	Couscous with Chicken and Peas
Thu	Pancakes from the Pantry	Chickpea Smash Sandwiches	Chicken Noodle Soup from Cans
Fri	Savory Oats with Egg and Bouillon	Mediterranean Chickpea Salad	Instant Rice and Black Beans
Sat	Peanut Butter and Raisin Crackers	White Bean and Olive Salad	Black Bean Soup with Salsa
Sun	Peanut Butter Oatmeal	Black Bean and Corn Salsa Salad	Mac and Cheese Cup

Snacks and morale items come from Layer 1: granola, trail mix, fruit cups, hard candy, cocoa. Swap any cell for another recipe with the same method — the index at the back lists every option by tag. In a real event the grid starts after fridge and freezer foods are used in safe order (see the timeline above).

The monthly pantry meal

Once a month, the household eats one full day of meals entirely from the emergency supply. Breakfast from the breakfast list, two main meals from Chapters 5–6, snacks from Layer 1. The meal accomplishes three things at once: it rotates stock, it scores meals under realistic conditions, and it teaches everyone where everything is. Score each dish on the taste-test sheet — five stars is a repeat, three or below is a donate-and-replace.

Use one, replace one

What happened	The rule
Ate a can of chili from the emergency shelf	Add chili to the next grocery list — same item, same size
Used a gallon of stored water	Rotate a fresh gallon in; mark the date on it
Ate cereal from the pantry box	Move the newest box to the back; buy one to refill the front
Opened a jar of peanut butter	Write the open date on the lid; plan its partner jar next

The meal scoring system

Score	Meaning	Action
5 / 5	Household favorite — would eat on any night	Stock extra; anchor of the menu grid
4 / 5	Good, with small tweaks (spice level, topping)	Keep; note the tweak on the card
3 / 5	Acceptable, unexciting	Keep in rotation, don't expand
2 / 5	Eaten reluctantly	Use up, do not rebuy
1 / 5	Rejected — kids pushed it away	Donate or discard; never stock again

Why scoring beats stockpiling

A pantry of ten five-star meals outperforms a pantry of forty untested ones in every measurable way: acceptance, rotation speed and cost. Scoring is the cheapest insurance against the classic failure — buying food you will never eat, twice.

CHAPTER 8

Family Acceptance and Dietary Substitutions

The universal meal formula, the flavor system, honest protein math, and adaptations for children, older adults, allergies and restricted diets.

The universal emergency meal formula

Every meal in this book is one instance of a single formula. Learn it and you can improvise a dinner from whatever cans are left:

BASE + PROTEIN + PRODUCE + FLAVOR + FAT or SAUCE

Swap any column — six worked examples

Base	Protein	Produce	Flavor	Fat / sauce
Pasta	Tuna	Canned tomatoes	Italian seasoning	Olive oil
Instant rice	Canned beans	Canned corn	Salsa + taco seasoning	Cheese sauce
Instant potatoes	Canned chicken	Canned peas	Bouillon + pepper	Gravy mix
Quick oats	Peanut butter	Raisins	Cinnamon	Honey + milk powder
Crackers	Tuna or salmon	Relish + fruit cup	Black pepper	Mayonnaise
Couscous	Canned chicken	Dehydrated vegetables	Bouillon + lemon	Olive oil

If one column is missing, substitute sideways — no base means a bowl (beans + produce + sauce); no protein means leaning on beans, lentils, cheese or nuts; no produce means extra seasoning and a fruit cup later.

The flavor system: beating menu fatigue

Menu fatigue — the point where safe food stops being appetizing — is real, and small flavor additions are the cheapest cure in the book. Stock a spice kit: salt, black pepper, bouillon cubes (chicken, beef, vegetable), garlic powder, onion powder, Italian seasoning, chili powder, taco seasoning, curry powder, and at least one hot sauce. Add shelf condiments: soy sauce, salsa, tomato sauce, mustard, relish, honey and jam.

Rule of thumb per 4-serving pot: 1–2 teaspoons dried herbs, 1 bouillon cube, or 1–2 tablespoons of a sauce — taste as you go. Serve spice on the side so adults get heat and children get mild. A drizzle of honey on oats, a spoon of salsa on rice, a splash of hot sauce on chili: these one-cent additions are the difference between tolerating your pantry and enjoying it.

Protein: what most pantries miss

A pantry of rice, pasta, flour and sugar is a calorie pantry, not a food supply — it is short on protein, fat and fiber, and meals built from it fatigue fast. Shelf-stable protein is the highest-value upgrade you can make, and grocery shelves carry more of it than most people realize: canned chicken, tuna, salmon, sardines, ham, chili and beans; dried beans, lentils and split peas; peanut butter and powdered peanut butter; powdered eggs; shelf-stable protein drinks; jerky; textured vegetable protein (TVP); and shelf-stable tofu where available.

The FDA's 50 g Daily Value for protein is a useful yardstick: plan meals that add up to roughly one to two labels' worth per adult per day, and verify with the products you actually buy. Sodium is the trade-off to watch — many canned proteins carry 20–40% of a day's sodium per serving.

Shelf-stable protein compared (typical grocery formats)

Protein source	Format	Preparation	Typical water need	Cooking	Allergen notes	Sodium notes	Verify
Canned chicken	Can / pouch	Ready to eat; warm if fuel allows	None (drain only)	None	None declared; check label	Moderate — compare brands	Check label
Canned tuna	Can / pouch	Ready to eat	None	None	Fish allergy	Moderate–high	Check label
Canned salmon	Can	Ready to eat	None	None	Fish allergy	Moderate	Check label
Sardines	Tin	Ready to eat	None	None	Fish allergy	High	Check label
Canned ham / luncheon meat	Can	Ready to eat or warm	None	None	Check sodium content	High	Check label
Canned chili / stews	Can	Warm gently	None	None	Beans = fiber; check allergens	High	Check label
Canned beans	Can	Ready; rinse to cut sodium	About 1 cup rinse (optional)	None	None declared	Moderate (less if rinsed)	Check label
Dried beans	Bag	Soak + long simmer, or can as substitute	About 3 cups absorbed per cup dry	High — prefer canned when fuel is tight	None declared	Very low until seasoned	Check label
Lentils (esp. red)	Bag	Simmer 15–25 min (red fastest)	About 2.5 cups absorbed per cup	Low–moderate	None declared	Very low	Check label
Split peas	Bag	Simmer 35–45 min	About 3 cups absorbed per cup	High	None declared	Very low	Check label
Peanut butter	Jar	Ready to eat	None	None	Peanut allergy — seed butters swap in	Low–moderate	Check label
Powdered peanut butter	Canister	Rehydrate per label (about 2 tbsp water per 2 tbsp powder)	About 2 tbsp per serving	None	Peanut allergy	Low	Check label
Powdered eggs	Canister	Rehydrate per label; cook if fuel allows	Per label	Low (cooking optional for scrambles)	Egg allergy	Low	Check label
Shelf-stable protein drinks	Carton	Ready to drink	None	None	Check dairy/soy content	Varies — often low	Check label
Jerky / meat sticks	Pouch	Ready to eat	None	None	Check allergens in marinades (soy common)	Very high — budget water	Check label
Textured vegetable protein (TVP)	Bag	Rehydrate in hot water or broth, 5–10 min	About 3/4 cup hot liquid per 1/2 cup dry	Hot water only	Check soy content	Low	Check label

Shelf-stable tofu appears in some markets in aseptic cartons; treat it like any canned protein: check the label, refrigerate after opening, and without power, eat it the same meal it is opened.

Fats: concentrated calories with an expiration date

Fats deliver more than twice the calories per ounce of carbohydrates or protein, and they carry flavor and cooking capability — but they are also the part of the pantry that goes rancid first. Stock peanut butter and other nut or seed butters, cooking oil, coconut oil, shortening, nuts and seeds, shelf-stable cheese products and canned olives, and rotate them by date: most oils keep about a year unopened in cool, dark storage and smell sharp or paint-like when turning. Brown rice and whole-grain flours carry their own oils and keep months, not years. The rule: **buy fats in sizes you will rotate within their label life.**

Fiber and produce get the same neglect in most lists. Canned vegetables, canned tomatoes, canned fruit, applesauce, fruit cups, dried and freeze-dried fruit, dehydrated vegetables, beans, lentils, oats and whole grains keep variety and fiber in the menu — not as medicine, but as the difference between a diet your family sustains and one they resent. Include at least two vegetable and two fruit items per person per day in your menu math.

Reading labels for emergencies

FDA Daily Values — your 5-second comparison tool (2,000-calorie reference diet)

Nutrient	Daily Value	How to use it in the aisle
Sodium	2,300 mg (less than)	Compare canned brands directly; 5% DV or less per serving is low, 20%+ is high. Balance high-sodium cans with no-salt-added items and extra water.
Added sugars	50 g (less than)	Fruit in juice beats fruit in heavy syrup; sauces and cereals vary wildly.
Dietary fiber	28 g (at least)	Beans, lentils, oats and whole grains earn their shelf space here.
Protein	50 g	Sum protein across the day's meals; many canned meats deliver 15–25 g per serving.
Saturated fat	20 g (less than)	Relevant for households managing cholesterol — check with a clinician.
Servings per container	—	Always compute can cost per serving, not per can — the big can is not always the cheaper serving.

Practical sodium strategies

Choose no-salt-added cans when the price is close · rinse canned beans if water allows · cut packaged seasoning packets in half · season with herbs, spices and citrus instead of salt · plan extra drinking water on high-sodium meal days · and for anyone on a medically restricted diet, make these choices with a clinician.

Children: familiarity beats novelty every time

Children eat what they recognize. Keep emergency portions of foods they already love — mac and cheese, pancakes, oatmeal, peanut butter crackers, pasta with tomato sauce, mild rice bowls, applesauce, cereal with shelf milk — and build new emergency foods through family taste tests while the lights are on. Serve spice and toppings on the side, keep portions small (seconds are better than waste), and use build-your-own formats so each child controls the outcome. For children with allergies, read every substitute label: seed butters replace peanut butter, oat milk cartons replace dairy, and "made on shared equipment" lines matter for some households.

Remember hydration: children dehydrate faster than adults in heat. Offer water on a schedule, not just on request, and favor salty-snack-and-water pairs over salty snacks alone.

Child-acceptance scorecard (rate at the family taste test)

Question	1-5
Ate it without being asked twice	
Recognized it as "normal food"	
Texture accepted (no spit-outs)	
Flavor mild enough at default seasoning	
Would ask for it again	

Older adults and access needs

- **Easy-open packaging:** prioritize pull-tab cans, pouches and single-serve formats; keep a backup opener and check hand-strength needs honestly.
- **Lower chewing effort:** instant mash, congee-style rice porridge, oatmeal, soft canned fruit, soups and smooth peanut butter all rate high.
- **Sodium and medication schedules:** plan low-sodium versions of the menu and store food where the routine already lives; medication timing is a household plan — confirm specifics with a clinician or pharmacist.
- **Vision-friendly labels:** mark shelves and cans with large-print tape labels (contents and dates).
- **Mobility:** store emergency food between knee and shoulder height — not on top shelves, not on the basement stairs.
- **Communication:** keep a written list of dietary needs and medications with the emergency kit for responders and relatives.

Infants

Breastfeeding can and should continue in emergencies. For formula-fed infants, CDC guidance is clear: ready-to-feed formula is the safest option (it needs no mixing water); never dilute formula to stretch it; use prepared formula within 2 hours of preparation — within 1 hour once feeding begins — and discard any leftovers from a started bottle. Clean feeding supplies carefully, or use disposable single-serve formats.

CHAPTER 9

Storage, Rotation and Food Safety

What dates actually mean, how long foods really keep, and the rotation habits that keep your supply fresh.

What the dates actually mean

USDA definitions — dates are about quality, with one exception

Label phrase	What it means
Best if Used By / Before	When the product is at best flavor or quality. Not a purchase or safety date.
Sell-By	Tells the store how long to display the product — inventory management only. Not a safety date.
Use-By	Last date recommended for peak quality. Not a safety date — except on infant formula, where it is federally required.
Freeze-By	When to freeze for peak quality. Not a safety date.

Except for infant formula, federal law does not require these dates, and foods without signs of spoilage are generally wholesome beyond a "Best if Used By" date (USDA). The exceptions are sensory and physical: off odors, mold, swelling, rust, deep dents and broken seals all mean discard — no tasting first.

Realistic shelf life: best-quality ranges

Unopened, stored cool, dry and dark — best-quality windows (USDA / extension guidance)

Food	Best quality	Notes
Canned goods, low-acid (meats, fish, beans, vegetables, soups, stews)	2–5 years	Longest-lived everyday format; can must stay intact
Canned goods, high-acid (tomatoes, fruit, pickles)	12–18 months	Acid slowly attacks the can lining
White rice, dry	About 2 years typical; much longer sealed oxygen-free and cool	Brown rice keeps only 6–12 months (oils)
Dry pasta (no egg)	About 2 years	Keep dry; humidity is the enemy
Quick / rolled oats	1–2 years	Airtight containers help
Dried beans, lentils, split peas	1–2 years best quality	Safe well beyond, but older beans take much longer to cook — rotate for fuel reasons alone
Peanut butter, commercial	6–9 months unopened; 2–3 months opened	Powdered peanut butter keeps longer — check label
Cooking oils	About 1 year	Smell before use; rancid oil smells like paint or old crayons
Shortening	Follow label (typically 1–2 years)	Keep sealed and cool
Shelf-stable milk cartons	Follow carton date (often 6–12 months)	Refrigerate after opening; without power, use single-serve sizes
Nonfat dry milk	Varies by packaging — follow label	Nitrogen-flushed cans keep longest
Powdered eggs	Follow label (commonly 1–3 years)	Refrigerate after reconstitution or opening per label
Jerky / meat sticks	Follow label (commonly 1–2 years)	Sodium-heavy; budget water
Crackers, cereal, granola	6–12 months	Stale before unsafe — re-crisp in a dry skillet if fuel allows
Honey, salt, white sugar	Indefinite when kept dry	Honey crystallizes; warm gently to restore
Freeze-dried / dehydrated commercial products	Varies widely by brand and packaging — years to decades	Verify the specific product's stated life; do not generalize

Shelf life depends on the food, the packaging, and temperature, moisture, oxygen, light and pests. Heat is the accelerator: every storage degree hotter ages food faster. These are best-quality planning windows — always defer to the package in your hand and to current USDA/FDA guidance.

Eight habits that rotate a pantry by themselves

1. **New goes behind old.** Every purchase slides behind the existing stock, like a grocery shelf.
2. **Mark the dates.** Purchase date on arrival, open date on the lid when opened — a paint pen on cans beats sticky notes.
3. **Keep a working pantry.** Emergency food lives with everyday food, not in a sealed tomb; you cannot rotate what you never touch.
4. **Eat one emergency meal weekly or monthly** (Chapter 7) and score it.
5. **Review inventory monthly** against the printed sheet in the back matter.
6. **Inspect quarterly:** cans for swelling, rust and deep dents; bags for pests and torn seals; oils by smell.
7. **Replace what was used** — the use-one-replace-one rule, same item, same size.
8. **Assign shelves by urgency:** shortest shelf life at eye level and in front; long-life staples behind and below.

Where to store — and where not to

Good storage is cool, dark, dry and pest-proof. Interior closets and pantries work; **hot garages and attics do not** — summer heat can push storage far above room temperature and ages food quickly. **Damp basements rust cans and grow mold;** if you must store there, keep food off the floor on shelving and watch humidity. Keep food away from gasoline, paints and cleaning chemicals, and never store non-food items on food shelves.

Keep labels intact and readable — an unlabeled can is a guessing game — and prefer packages sized to one meal: a #10 can or a 25-pound bag is only practical if you can use it quickly once opened. Smaller packages rotate faster, store safer and cost a little more; for most households the trade is worth it.

Packaging methods, honestly

Method	Good for	Limitations
Original commercial packaging	Everything you rotate within its date	None, if intact and dated
Food-grade buckets with lids	Bagged staples added as an outer pest/moisture barrier	Not airtight alone; still needs a cool room
Mylar bags + oxygen absorbers	Low-moisture dry staples (rice, oats, beans, pasta) for multi-year storage per extension guidance	Not for high-moisture or high-oil foods; absorbers don't belong with sugar or salt; method must match the food — check university-extension instructions
Airtight canning jars	Small quantities of dry goods; excellent visibility	Light passes through — store dark; breakable
Vacuum sealing	Short- to mid-term freshness of dry goods	Bags puncture; not a substitute for oxygen absorbers in long storage
Cans (commercial)	The default — already sealed, cooked and durable	Weight; dents, rust and swelling disqualify

Home canning: this book's policy

This book intentionally contains no home-canning procedures. Botulism is odorless and invisible, and safe home canning requires tested, up-to-date processes followed exactly. If you home-can, use the current guides from the National Center for Home Food Preservation (see Sources) and discard — do not taste — anything from a jar with a broken seal, bulging lid, spurting liquid or off appearance.

After the power returns: keep or toss

USDA FSIS guidance for a refrigerator without power for more than 4 hours (door closed). Never taste food to test it.

Discard after 4+ hours above 40 °F	Generally keep
Raw or cooked meat, poultry, seafood · milk, cream, yogurt, soft cheeses · eggs and egg dishes · leftovers and casseroles · cut fruits and vegetables · opened mayo-based salads · custards and cream-filled pastries	Hard and processed cheeses · butter and margarine · whole uncut fruits and vegetables · bread and tortillas · opened ketchup, mustard, relish, taco sauce, pickles, jams · peanut butter · opened fruit juices · shelf-stable items unopened

Freezer rule

Frozen food that still has ice crystals, or that reads 40 °F or below, can be refrozen or cooked — quality may suffer, safety holds. Thawed-and-warm items follow the same discard rules as refrigerated food. Photograph discarded food before bagging it if you may file an insurance or assistance claim.

Opened packages without refrigeration

Opened item	Plan when power is out
Canned meats, beans, vegetables	Eat the full can this meal. If you must hold it, transfer to a clean covered non-metal container and use within 2 hours at room temperature — otherwise discard.
Shelf-stable milk cartons	Buy single-serve sizes for emergencies; an opened liter cannot be saved without cold.
Peanut butter	Keeps well opened; wipe the rim, keep the lid tight, use clean utensils.
Crackers, cereal, granola	Clip or fold the liner; staleness is quality, not safety.
Jams, honey, mustard, hot sauce	Generally fine unrefrigerated for the short term per most labels; use clean utensils, wipe rims, and follow the specific label when it says otherwise.
Cooking oil	Fine unrefrigerated; cap tight, keep from light.

Flood salvage — the narrow exception

Food touched by floodwater is discarded — with one exception USDA describes: undamaged, commercially canned items in waterproof cans. Remove labels, wash in soapy water, sanitize for 15 minutes in a solution of 1 tablespoon unscented household bleach per gallon of water, air-dry, and relabel with a marker. Everything else — cardboard boxes, screw-top jars, plastic pouches, wooden items, damaged cans — goes out with the trash. Assume floodwater carries sewage and chemicals.

CHAPTER 10

Cooking Without Electricity

Every safe way to heat food when the grid is down — and the fuel math that keeps you cooking for days instead of hours.

Carbon monoxide warning — read before cooking

Never use generators, charcoal grills, camp stoves, propane heaters or other fuel-burning appliances indoors or in enclosed or partially enclosed spaces — including garages, carports, tents and screened porches — unless specifically approved for that environment and used exactly as directed. Cook outdoors at least 20 feet from windows, doors and vents, with exhaust away from the house. Keep a battery-powered or battery-backup carbon monoxide alarm in the home. CO is colorless and odorless; headache, dizziness, nausea or confusion means fresh air immediately — then 911.

The method table

Capabilities, placement and honest limits

Method	Placement	Best at	Does not solve
Propane camp stove	Outdoors only	Fast boiling, real simmering; the workhorse of outage cooking	Indoor cooking; running out of fuel
Butane table stove	Outdoors or as the label permits; never enclosed	Lightweight boiling; smaller canisters	Cold-weather output drops; check the stove's rating
Charcoal / gas grill	Outdoors only, 10+ ft from siding	Batch cooking, grilling, Dutch-oven work	Wind and rain; precise simmering
Campfire (where legal & safe)	Designated fire-safe area	Long simmers with free fuel	Reliability, weather, fire restrictions and burn risk
Solar cooker	Direct sun, outdoors	Fuel-free cooking in sunny climates	Night, clouds, winter, speed — it is a slow method
Thermos / insulated-pot cooking	Anywhere safe to pour boiling water	Couscous, rice, oats, soups — boil briefly, then the vessel finishes the job	Raw meats or anything needing sustained high heat
No-cook	Anywhere	First 72 hours; zero fuel and water	Hot-meal morale — rotate back when fuel allows

Fuel planning that does not pretend

Exact fuel numbers depend on stove, pot, wind and altitude, so plan in meal-types rather than minutes. As a rough planning anchor (not a guarantee), a standard 16.4 oz propane cylinder on a small camp stove will typically bring roughly 8–12 gallons of water to a boil over its life — enough for a family's hot-water meals for several days if meals are chosen for fuel thrift, or one long weekend of real cooking if they are not. Buy your own fuel, time one boil at home, and do the arithmetic for your own stove — ten minutes of practice replaces guesswork.

Charcoal math: plan roughly 30 briquettes per large-pot meal. Butane canisters boil about 3–5 liters each in typical conditions. In every case, choose meals by fuel category from the recipe spec strips and spend the big fuel on batch days, not daily simmering.

Fuel thrift, in order of impact

1. **Choose short-cook foods:** instant rice, instant potatoes, couscous, quick-cooking lentils and quick oats before pasta, and pasta before dry beans.
2. **Soak when safe:** an overnight soak in cool, clean conditions cuts bean cook time; in warm conditions without refrigeration, use canned beans instead.
3. **Lids on, always** — a covered pot boils faster and holds heat for the steep.
4. **Thermos-finish everything you can:** boil 2–5 minutes, then let an insulated vessel finish rice, couscous, oats and soups off the flame.
5. **One pot, one meal, one cleanup;** batch cook only when leftovers can be handled safely.
6. **Windbreaks** for outdoor stoves — wind can double fuel use.
7. **Skip the boil** entirely on no-cook days; hot morale can come from cocoa or broth heated in a cup's worth of water.

Water thrift, meal by meal

Every recipe card shows its water number. The pattern behind the numbers:

Choice	Water effect
Instant oats, couscous, instant rice, instant potatoes	Water absorbed — no dishwater, roughly 1–1.5 cups per serving
Canned foods eaten as-is	Nearly zero beyond drinking water
Pasta boiled in lots of water and drained	Most expensive common meal — 6–8+ cups per pot, plus rinse; reuse cooking water for sanitation, not drinking
One-pot meals where liquid becomes sauce	Moderate — most water ends up in the meal
Rinsing canned beans	Costs about a cup per can and cuts sodium; decide day by day
Dishwashing	Minimize with disposable plates, one-pot meals, and a covered wash basin rather than running water; dispose of gray water outdoors, away from wells and waterways

Practice once before you need it

One dry-run weekend per year — cook one meal on the camp stove, fill the thermos, eat a pantry dinner. The household learns the kit, you learn your fuel math, and the emergency stops being the first time anyone has touched any of it.

CHAPTER 11

Disaster-Specific Playbooks

Ten scenarios, each with its likely food challenge, the format that fits it, and the first five moves.

How to use the playbooks

Each scenario below lists the likely food challenge, the best food format, water and cooking concerns, storage concerns, first actions, foods to avoid, and what to stage near the exit. Pair them with your local emergency-management guidance — Ready.gov and your county's alerts — which always outrank a book.

Hurricane

Playbook

- **Likely challenge:** Multi-day power and water loss after a warned event; roads may be blocked for days.
- **Best food format:** Layer 1 no-cook supplies plus 7–14 days of Layers 2–3; single-serve formats for no refrigeration.
- **Water concern:** Fill everything before landfall: jugs, tubs (for sanitation only), washer drums. Plan 1+ gallon/person/day for up to two weeks.
- **Cooking concern:** Camp stove outdoors, 20+ ft from the house; stock fuel for hot-water meals. Never grill indoors.
- **Storage concern:** High shelves away from flood-prone areas; freeze water jugs now to extend cold time.
- **First actions:** Follow evacuation orders immediately if issued; Freeze containers of water; Charge power banks; preset fridge to coldest; Stage 3 days of no-cook food + can opener in one bin; Photograph pantry for insurance.
- **Avoid:** Cooking with charcoal indoors or in the garage; foods that need refrigeration once the power goes; storing anything on the floor in surge zones..
- **Stage near the exit:** Bin with water, 3 days of no-cook food, can opener, meds, documents — staged at the door when a watch is issued.

Flood

Playbook

- **Likely challenge:** Contamination — floodwater can carry sewage, fuel and chemicals; anything it touches is suspect.
- **Best food format:** Sealed, waterproof formats: cans and pouches; avoid formats you may have to abandon at ground level.
- **Water concern:** Assume tap water is compromised until cleared. Boil or disinfect per Chapter 3; 'do not drink' advisories mean bottled water only.
- **Cooking concern:** Often limited to no-cook until waters recede; outdoor stove only from dry, safe ground.
- **Storage concern:** Move food to upper floors or high shelves before the event; discard all flood-touched food except intact waterproof cans, salvaged per Chapter 9.
- **First actions:** Move food and water upward before water arrives; Seal documents and meds in waterproof bags; Listen for boil-water advisories; Plan meals that need no water beyond drinking.
- **Avoid:** Eating any food touched by floodwater; Drinking untreated tap water after flooding; Walking or driving through floodwater for supplies.
- **Stage near the exit:** Waterproof bag: bottled water, pouch meals, utensils, meds.

Winter storm

Playbook

- **Likely challenge:** Power lines fail under ice; delivery stops; but cold gives you a backup refrigerator outside (in shade, secured from animals, below 40 °F).
- **Best food format:** Hot one-pot meals dominate — morale and body heat both benefit; keep 3 days of no-cook food in case the stove is unusable.
- **Water concern:** Pipes can freeze: fill tubs and jugs before the storm. Do not eat snow straight — melt and boil it; it lowers body temperature and may carry contaminants.
- **Cooking concern:** Camp stove outdoors or in a ventilated, approved setup only. Carbon monoxide risk spikes in winter — alarms on, generators outside.
- **Storage concern:** Unheated garage can be a freezer in this scenario and an oven in summer — use it situationally, with a thermometer.
- **First actions:** Fill jugs and tubs; Cook and freeze nothing; instead freeze water; Stock extra propane/butane before the storm; Plan hot breakfasts — oats, cocoa.
- **Avoid:** Heating the house with the oven or unvented heaters; running cars in attached garages; any indoor charcoal..
- **Stage near the exit:** Car kit (see Car/roadside) plus a bin of hot-meal ingredients near the stove.

Tornado

Playbook

- **Likely challenge:** Minutes of warning; possible damage to the house itself, including the pantry; utilities may fail locally.
- **Best food format:** A compact go-bin of no-cook food and water that fits in the shelter area itself.
- **Water concern:** Small stored amount in the shelter area (1 gallon/person) plus the main supply elsewhere.
- **Cooking concern:** Assume nothing until damage is checked; no-cook first, outdoor stove only if the area is safe.
- **Storage concern:** Spread supplies across two locations so one destroyed room does not take the whole supply.
- **First actions:** Know your shelter spot and put a snack/water bin in it; After: check cans and jars before eating — discard damaged ones; Smell-check for gas before any flame.
- **Avoid:** Using flames before checking for gas leaks; Eating from crushed, dented or open cans found in debris.
- **Stage near the exit:** The shelter bin stays in the shelter: water bars, pouches, can opener, flashlight.

Wildfire evacuation

Playbook

- **Likely challenge:** Leave fast, possibly for days; smoke, heat and ash; shelter or hotel living with no kitchen.
- **Best food format:** Evacuation meals: package-eaten, no-cook, heat-tolerant; nothing in glass.
- **Water concern:** Bottled water in the car — one gallon per person minimum for the first days.
- **Cooking concern:** None while evacuating; a car-bin camp stove only when stopped somewhere safe and legal.
- **Storage concern:** What stays home may sit in smoke and ash — keep the deep pantry sealed in bins.
- **First actions:** Keep the car bin topped off year-round (see Car/roadside); Grab-and-go bag: pouches, bars, fruit cups, utensils, trash bags; Medications and allergen info packed with the food.
- **Avoid:** Foods that melt or spoil in a hot parked car (chocolate, mayo-based items, soft cheese); Returning home before clearance to restock.
- **Stage near the exit:** Everything edible lives in the go-bag and car bin — never in the trunk under summer sun.

Earthquake

Playbook

- **Likely challenge:** No warning; broken glass and open cans in the pantry; gas and water mains may be disrupted.
- **Best food format:** Cans and pouches survive shaking; glass jars do not. Favor metal and flexible packaging.
- **Water concern:** Water heater and jugs may survive; assume mains are suspect until cleared — treat per Chapter 3.
- **Cooking concern:** Check for gas leaks before any flame; then outdoor stove as usual.
- **Storage concern:** Secure shelves to walls; heavy cans low; latches on cabinet doors prevent the pantry becoming shrapnel.
- **First actions:** After shaking: shoes on, check cans for damage, photograph losses; Shut off gas if you smell it, before cooking anything; Eat undamaged ready foods first.
- **Avoid:** Lighting any stove before checking for gas odor; Eating from broken-seal or punctured cans.
- **Stage near the exit:** Go-bag by the door; earthquake-prone homes should keep a 72-hour bin in the car too.

Extended power outage

Playbook

- **Likely challenge:** Days to weeks without power — the core scenario this book is built for; food safety and morale are the grind.
- **Best food format:** Full three-layer system in order: fridge → freezer → Layer 1 → Layer 2 → Layer 3.
- **Water concern:** Track consumption daily against the Chapter 3 table; refill from treatment if needed.
- **Cooking concern:** Rotate methods by fuel budget: no-cook days alternate with hot-water days; one-pot batch days when fuel allows.
- **Storage concern:** Appliance thermometers decide the keep/toss calls (Chapter 9).
- **First actions:** Note the outage time on the fridge; Doors closed; plan openings in batches; Freeze water jugs if they have not thawed; Start the menu grid from Chapter 7.
- **Avoid:** Rationing drinking water; Opening cans 'just in case'; Refrigerating without power and hoping.
- **Stage near the exit:** Not evacuation — instead stage fuel, light and the go-bin in case the outage becomes an evacuation.

Short-term grocery shortage

Playbook

- **Likely challenge:** Empty shelves of specific staples for days to weeks — not a disaster, but a supply-chain hiccup.
- **Best food format:** Your rotating pantry is the answer; this is what weekly rotation buys you.
- **Water concern:** Store tap water or buy bottled while it is available; shortages often hit bottled water first.
- **Cooking concern:** Normal kitchen; use the meal formula to substitute around the missing item.
- **Storage concern:** No change — rotation continues; do not hoard beyond your plan.
- **First actions:** Substitute columns in the meal formula (rice out → pasta in); Check two or three stores or order pickup before assuming scarcity; Replenish used items as they appear.
- **Avoid:** Panic-buying beyond your documented plan; Buying unfamiliar bulk items you will not eat.
- **Stage near the exit:** N/A — keep the car kit stocked regardless.

Temporary income disruption

Playbook

• **Likely challenge:** The budget, not the weather, is the emergency — food still has to appear every night.

• **Best food format:** The same pantry, eaten as dinner: budget meals from the index stretch dollars at any income level.

• **Water concern:** Tap water is fine in most U.S. municipalities; if finances are tight, skip bottled and treat tap when advisories say so.

• **Cooking concern:** Normal kitchen; one-pot meals cut both time and energy use.

• **Storage concern:** Eat down the pantry deliberately and rebuild with the cheapest staples first: rice, beans, oats, canned vegetables.

• **First actions:** Switch to the budget-meal index; Contact local food banks or dial 211 for assistance programs — using them early preserves the pantry; If you receive SNAP/EBT, ask about disaster replacement benefits.

• **Avoid:** High-cost convenience formats while income is disrupted; Skipping meals to stretch food — reduce portions and add calories cheaply (oil, sugar, grains) instead.

• **Stage near the exit:** N/A.

Car / roadside emergency

Playbook

• **Likely challenge:** Hours to overnight stuck or displaced; heat or cold inside the vehicle; no kitchen at all.

• **Best food format:** Package-eaten only: bars, trail mix, jerky, pouches, crackers, nut butter packets, single-serve fruit.

• **Water concern:** One gallon per occupant minimum; more in remote or hot-country driving.

• **Cooking concern:** None inside the vehicle, ever; a stove outside and downwind only when stopped safely.

• **Storage concern:** Rotate the car bin every season — summer trunk heat ruins chocolate, soft items and some plastics within weeks.

• **First actions:** Stock the bin in a cloth bag, not loose in the trunk; Include utensils, napkins, trash bags, and any medications or allergen cards; Check the water each season.

• **Avoid:** Anything in glass; Mayo- or dairy-based items in warm months; Leaving the bin in a parked summer car long-term.

• **Stage near the exit:** The bin lives in the car permanently; it doubles as the wildfire evacuation food kit.

CHAPTER 12

Worksheets and Checklists

Every printable tool in one place — print these pages and keep them with the pantry.

The paperwork that makes it stick

All worksheets print on this same Letter paper with clean lines to write on. Keep them in a folder taped inside the pantry door, or clip them to the shelf itself.

Tool	Use it	Where
Staged shopping lists	Weeks 1–4 of the build, then replenishment	Back matter
Pantry inventory	Record every purchase; monthly review	Back matter
Rotation tracker	What was eaten, what was replaced, open dates	Back matter
Taste-test sheet	Score new meals; keep only 4–5 star foods	Back matter
Water calculator	Household × days × gallons, plus pets and heat	Back matter
Fuel calculator	Meals × fuel category against your tested stove	Back matter
Dietary substitution chart	Swap the formula's columns for restricted diets	Back matter
Recipe index	Every recipe by method, tag and fuel	Back matter

The household readiness checklist

1. Everyone in the household knows where the food, water, can opener and flashlight live.
2. Everyone knows the outdoor cooking spot and the "never indoors" rule.
3. Emergency contacts are written down (phones die): out-of-state contact, pediatrician, pharmacy, utility, 211.
4. Medications and dietary-needs list are packed with the go-bag.
5. Pets have food, water, a leash/carrier and a feeding plan (never share human emergency rations as a diet).
6. Infants: ready-to-feed formula and feeding supplies staged; formula is never diluted.
7. One practice meal has been eaten this season, and the results are on the taste-test sheet.

Digital copies

Photograph the completed worksheets and keep copies in cloud storage — paper in a flood is just as lost as food in a flood.

CHAPTER 13

Sources and Further Reading

The federal, extension and institutional sources this book relies on — and what to read next.

Primary sources used in this book

Guidance changes. The URLs below were current at publication; when they disagree with this book, trust the current official page. Full reference list in the Sources section of the back matter.

- **USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service** — power-outage food safety (the 4-hour refrigerator rule, 48/24-hour freezer rule, keep/discard lists); "Food Product Dating" (date-label definitions; high-acid vs. low-acid canned shelf life); "The Danger Zone" (40–140 °F, the 2-hour rule); severe-storm and hurricane consumer guides.
- **FEMA / Ready.gov** — one gallon of water per person per day; several-days-to-two-weeks food and water planning; "never ration drinking water"; generator placement (20+ feet); disaster kit contents; pet preparedness.
- **EPA** — emergency disinfection of drinking water (boiling times by altitude; household bleach dosing table for 6% and 8.25% sodium hypochlorite; 30-minute contact time).
- **CDC** — carbon monoxide poisoning basics; infant feeding in emergencies (ready-to-feed formula; never dilute; 2-hour/1-hour prepared-formula rules; breastfeeding continuity).
- **FDA** — Nutrition Facts Daily Values (sodium 2,300 mg; protein 50 g; fiber 28 g; added sugars 50 g); food labeling.
- **USDA Dietary Guidelines for Americans** — typical calorie ranges used only as planning aids.
- **National Center for Home Food Preservation** — the authoritative home-canning reference (this book provides no canning procedures; see them before canning anything).
- **Cooperative Extension publications** (e.g., Virginia Tech, University of Wyoming, Utah State, UF/IFAS) — food-storage charts and power-outage triage used to sanity-check ranges in Chapters 3 and 9.
- **CPSC** — generator and charcoal safety releases; CO shut-off standards.
- **American Red Cross** — "Food and Water in an Emergency" (FEMA/ARC P-0033 lineage) for storage and rotation basics.

Read next

- Ready.gov plan and kit pages (ready.gov) — communications plan, kit contents, alerts.
- USDA FoodKeeper guidance for item-by-item storage clocks.
- Your county emergency-management site for local hazards, evacuation zones and alert signup.
- NCHFP canning guides, if you ever take up home canning — and only their current, tested processes.

Food-safety references

- USDA FSIS — "Keeping Food Safe During an Emergency / Power Outage" guidance (fsis.usda.gov): refrigerator and freezer timeframes, keep/discard lists, thermometer use, dry-ice guidance.
- USDA FSIS — "A Consumer's Guide to Food Safety: Severe Storms and Hurricanes" (fsis.usda.gov): appliance thermometers, freezing water containers, refreezing rules.
- USDA FSIS — "Food Product Dating" (fsis.usda.gov): definitions of Best-if-Used-By, Sell-By, Use-By; canned-food best-quality windows; can defect rules.
- USDA FSIS — "How Temperatures Affect Food" / "Danger Zone" fact sheet (fsis.usda.gov): 40–140 °F zone, 2-hour rule, 1-hour rule above 90 °F, 165 °F reheating.
- FDA — "Daily Value on the Nutrition and Supplement Facts Labels" (fda.gov): sodium 2,300 mg, protein 50 g, fiber 28 g, added sugars 50 g, saturated fat 20 g.
- CDC — "Facts About Infant Feeding During Emergencies" (cdc.gov): ready-to-feed formula guidance, never dilute, prepared-formula time limits.
- National Center for Home Food Preservation — nchfp.uga.edu: tested home-canning processes (referenced, not reproduced).
- Cooperative Extension: Virginia Tech FST-518 (power-outage keep/discard), University of Wyoming food-storage chart, UF/IFAS 2-hour rule guidance.

Emergency-management references

- FEMA / Ready.gov — food and water emergency supply guidance: one gallon per person per day; two-week goal; never ration water; commercially bottled water preferred (ready.gov/food, ready.gov/water).
- FEMA / ARC — "Food and Water in an Emergency" (FEMA P-0033 lineage): two quarts drinking minimum, storage and treatment basics.
- EPA — "Emergency Disinfection of Drinking Water" (epa.gov): boiling by altitude, bleach dosing table, contact times.
- CDC — Carbon Monoxide Poisoning Basics (cdc.gov/carbon-monoxide): generator placement, indoor prohibitions, alarm guidance.
- CPSC — hurricane-season generator/CO hazard warnings (cpsc.gov): outdoor-only operation, CO shut-off standards.
- Ready.gov — generator safety, winter weather (#WinterReady), pets, evacuation planning.

Citation format note: this book summarizes guidance in plain language; for medical, legal or regulatory decisions, consult the cited pages directly.

Family-of-four quantities. Singles and couples: divide by 4 or 2. Check boxes as items go into the cart; write prices to track your real cost. Prices vary by region and season. Weeks 3–4 continue on the next page.

Got it	Week 1 — Ready	Got it	Week 1 notes
☐	Water: 2 cases bottled or 8 one-gallon jugs		
☐	2 manual can openers		
☐	8 pouches/cans tuna or chicken		
☐	2 jars peanut butter (or seed butter)		
☐	1 pack jerky or meat sticks		
☐	4 sleeves crackers + 1 pack tortillas		
☐	8 single-serve shelf milks		
☐	8 fruit cups / applesauce cups		
☐	Hand sanitizer, trash bags, paper plates		

Got it	Week 2 — Staples	Got it	Week 2 notes
☐	Instant rice (2 lb) + couscous (1 lb)		
☐	Quick oats (42 oz) + instant potatoes (2 boxes)		
☐	Pasta (4 × 1 lb) + ramen (12 packets)		
☐	8 cans beans (mixed) + 1 lb each dry lentils/beans		
☐	12 cans vegetables + 6 cans tomatoes		
☐	6 cans fruit		

Continued from the previous page. Week 3 buys flavor; Week 4 buys capability.

Got it	Week 3 — Flavor	Got it	Week 3 notes
☐	Cooking oil (48 oz) + shortening (small)		
☐	3 jars pasta sauce + 1 jar salsa + mustard/relish		
☐	Bouillon + taco + Italian seasoning + salt/pepper		
☐	Shelf milk cartons (4 qt) + powdered milk (1 box)		
☐	Mac and cheese (4 boxes) + pancake mix + honey		
☐	Coffee/tea + hard candy or comfort treats		
Got it	Week 4 — Capability	Got it	Week 4 notes
☐	Camp stove fuel (2 cylinders) or charcoal (1 bag)		
☐	Thermos / insulated vessel		
☐	Storage bins + label tape + paint pen		
☐	Special-diet items for your household		

Log every emergency item once, then keep it current during the monthly review. Mark location codes (P = pantry, C = closet, G = garage shelf, B = bin).

Item	Qty	Loc.	Bought	Best-by	Opened	Score	Done

Quarterly inspection: check cans for swelling/rust/deep dents, bags for pests and torn seals, oils by smell. Anything failing goes to the front of the line to be eaten this week or discarded.

One line per item used. The golden rule: use one, replace one – same item, same size, on the next grocery run.

Date	Item used	Meal it went into	Household score	Replaced

Monthly pantry meal	Date	Menu eaten	What to fix next month

Test every new item on an ordinary evening, before it earns shelf space. Score 1–5 per person; foods averaging below 4 do not get bought in quantity.

Recipe / product	Date	Adult 1	Adult 2	Child 1	Child 2	Notes / tweaks	Stock?

Prompt the table with the same three questions every time: Would you eat this on a normal Tuesday? What would make it better? Would you ask for seconds?

Baseline: 1 gallon per person per day (FEMA), split roughly half drinking, half preparation and sanitation. Add for heat, activity, pregnancy, illness, and pets.

Household member	Gallons / day (1+)	× 3 days	× 7 days	× 14 days	× 30 days
Pets (1 oz water / lb body weight / day)					
TOTALS					

Adjustment	Applied?
Hot climate or summer planning — add up to 50%	☐
Heavy physical work planned during the event	☐
Pregnant or nursing adult, infants on formula	☐
Cooking-water needs of your chosen menu (sum recipe cards)	☐
Treatment supplies staged: bleach (fresh) and/or tablets, per Chapter 3	☐

Test your stove once: time a full boil of 1 quart and note how many full boils one fuel unit gives you. Then plan meals against that real number instead of guesses.

My tested baseline	My number
Minutes to boil 1 quart on my stove	
Full boils per 16.4 oz propane cylinder (or per butane canister / lb charcoal)	
Boils needed for one week of my menu (count hot-water + one-pot cards)	
Fuel units needed for 3 / 7 / 14 days	

Meal-type fuel budget (recipe spec strips)	Count	Boils / meal (approx.)
No-cook meals (0 boils)		0
Hot-water meals (1 boil each)		1
Low-fuel one-pot (1–2 boils)		1–2
Moderate-fuel one-pot (2–3 boils of simmer equivalent)		2–3
High-fuel meals (long simmers — use sparingly)		4+

Lids on, windbreaks up, thermos-finishng wherever possible — those three habits can cut the numbers above by roughly a third.

Apply these swaps inside the universal meal formula. Medical diets: confirm specifics with a clinician or registered dietitian.

Restriction	Swap in	Watch out for
Gluten-free	Rice, instant rice, corn grits, certified GF oats, quinoa, potatoes, corn tortillas; rice noodles for ramen	"Wheat" hides in soy sauce, bouillon and some crackers — read every label
Dairy-free	Shelf oat/soy/pea milks, oil instead of butter powder, skip cheese powders; sardines/salmon for calcium-bearing variety	Many cream-style soups contain dairy; many "cheese" sauces do too
Vegetarian	Beans, lentils, split peas, TVP, nuts, seeds, peanut butter, canned vegetarian chili and soups	Check "made with" lines on broths and seasonings; bouillons vary
Nut allergy	Sunflower or pumpkin seed butters, seeds in trail mix, bean-based proteins	Granolas, cereals and "shared equipment" labels are the usual traps
Fish / shellfish allergy	Canned chicken, ham, beans and lentils replace tuna/salmon/sardines 1:1	Some Worcestershire-style sauces contain anchovy
Low-sodium	No-salt-added cans, rinsed beans, half seasoning packets, herb-forward flavoring, low-sodium broths	Do this in partnership with a clinician; plan extra water either way
Diabetes management	Pair carbs with protein/fat at every meal; favor beans, lentils, vegetables; portion quick grains	Individual plans differ greatly — build the menu with your care team
Soft-food / low-chew needs	Mashed potatoes, congee, oatmeal, smooth nut butters, soups, applesauce, scrambled powdered egg	Serve slightly warm, not hot; check with a clinician for swallowing disorders
Egg allergy	Skip powdered egg; extra beans, dairy or meats; many noodles contain egg — choose rice pasta	Some pancake mixes contain egg; check labels
Soy allergy	Skip soy sauce (use coconut aminos or salt + bouillon), tofu and some TVP	Soy hides in tuna packets, broths and many jerky marinades

No-cook meals (22)

Recipe	Serves	Water	Fuel	Dishes
Tuna Salad on Crackers High-protein · Evacuation-ready · Low-water · Kid-friendly	2	None	No-cook	1
Chickpea Smash Sandwiches High-protein · Budget · Kid-friendly	2	None (draining only)	No-cook	1
Peanut Butter and Raisin Crackers Kid-friendly · Evacuation-ready · Low-water · Budget · Breakfast	2	None	No-cook	0
Mediterranean Chickpea Salad High-protein · Budget	2	None (draining only)	No-cook	1
Salmon Salad on Crispbread High-protein · Evacuation-ready	2	None	No-cook	1
Granola Breakfast Bowl Breakfast · Kid-friendly · Evacuation-ready · Low-water	1	None	No-cook	1
White Bean and Olive Salad High-protein · Budget	2	None (draining only)	No-cook	1
Ham and Cheese Cracker Stack Kid-friendly · Evacuation-ready · Low-water · High-protein	2	None	No-cook	0
Black Bean and Corn Salsa Salad Budget · High-protein	3	None (draining only)	No-cook	1
Peanut Butter Tortilla Roll-Ups Kid-friendly · Breakfast · Evacuation-ready · Low-water · Budget	2	None	No-cook	0
Sardine Toast with Mustard High-protein · Evacuation-ready · Low-water	1	None	No-cook	0
Pantry Antipasto Plate Evacuation-ready · High-protein	2	None	No-cook	1
Applesauce Granola Cups Kid-friendly · Breakfast · Budget	2	None	No-cook	1
Chicken Salad Wraps High-protein · Evacuation-ready	2	None	No-cook	1
Fruit Parfait Cups Kid-friendly · Low-water · Budget	2	None	No-cook	1
Overnight-Style Oats with Peanut Butter Breakfast · Budget	1	3/4 cup per serving (safe, cold)	No-cook	1
Pantry Snack Board for Kids Kid-friendly · Evacuation-ready · Low-water	2	None	No-cook	1
Bean Dip and Chips Budget · High-protein · Kid-friendly	3	None (draining only)	No-cook	1
Trail Mix Energy Bowls Evacuation-ready · Low-water · Budget	1	None	No-cook	0
Cinnamon Cereal Cups Kid-friendly · Breakfast · Evacuation-ready · Low-water	1	None	No-cook	1
Jerky, Nuts and Dried Fruit Plate High-protein · Evacuation-ready · Low-water	2	None	No-cook	1
Sardine and White Bean Mash High-protein · Budget	2	None (draining only)	No-cook	1

Method for all rows: No-cook meals. Every recipe also carries the standard label-verification note: check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Hot-water meals (22)

Recipe	Serves	Water	Fuel	Dishes
Peanut Butter Oatmeal Breakfast · Kid-friendly · Budget	1	About 1 cup per serving (absorbed)	Hot water only	1
Couscous with Chicken and Peas High-protein · Low-water	2	About 1 1/4 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1
Upgraded Ramen Bowl Budget · Kid-friendly	1	About 2 cups (partly absorbed)	Hot water only	1
Instant Mash and Gravy Chicken Bowl Kid-friendly · High-protein · Comfort food	2	About 1 3/4 cups total (absorbed)	Hot water only	1
Thermos Tomato Pasta Evacuation-ready · Kid-friendly	1	About 2 cups (mostly absorbed)	Hot water only	1
Instant Rice and Black Beans Budget · High-protein	2	About 1 1/2 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1
Creamy Tomato Soup with Pasta Kid-friendly · Comfort food · Budget	2	About 3 cups total	Hot water only	1
Breakfast Couscous with Cinnamon Breakfast · Low-water	2	About 1 1/4 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1
Miso-Style Noodle Cup Evacuation-ready · Budget	1	About 1 3/4 cups	Hot water only	1
Red Lentil Stew High-protein · Budget	2	About 2 1/2 cups (mostly absorbed)	Low	1
Chicken Congee with Instant Rice High-protein · Comfort food	2	About 3 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1
Tabbouleh-Style Couscous Salad Low-water	2	About 1 1/4 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1
Mac and Cheese Cup Kid-friendly · Comfort food · Budget	1	About 2 cups (pasta absorbed)	Low	1
Chili Over Instant Potatoes High-protein · Comfort food · Kid-friendly	2	About 1 1/2 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1
Thai-Style Peanut Noodles Kid-friendly · High-protein	2	About 3 cups (mostly absorbed)	Low	1
Cheddar Potato Soup Comfort food · Kid-friendly	2	About 2 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1
Cinnamon Raisin Oatmeal Breakfast · Kid-friendly · Budget	2	About 1 3/4 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1
Savory Oats with Egg and Bouillon Breakfast · High-protein	1	About 1 1/4 cups (absorbed)	Hot water only	1
Ham and Potato Soup High-protein · Comfort food	2	About 2 cups (absorbed)	Low	1
Dehydrated Vegetable Soup Budget · Low-water	2	About 3 cups	Low	1
Instant Polenta with Tomato Sauce Comfort food · Budget	2	About 2 cups (absorbed)	Low	1
Bulgur Pilaf with Chickpeas High-protein · Budget	2	About 1 3/4 cups (absorbed)	Low	1

Method for all rows: Hot-water meals. Every recipe also carries the standard label-verification note: check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

One-pot meals (26)

Recipe	Serves	Water	Fuel	Dishes
Chili Mac Kid-friendly · Comfort food · High-protein	4	About 3 cups	Moderate	1
Pantry Three-Bean Chili High-protein · Budget · Comfort food	4	About 1 cup	Moderate	1
Red Beans and Rice Budget · High-protein	4	About 2 1/2 cups	Moderate	1
Chicken Noodle Soup from Cans Kid-friendly · Comfort food · High-protein	4	About 6 cups	Moderate	1
Pasta with Marinara Kid-friendly · Budget · Comfort food	4	About 8 cups for boiling	Moderate	1
Tuna Noodle Skillet High-protein · Budget	3	About 6 cups for boiling	Moderate	1
Hearty Lentil Soup Budget · High-protein	4	About 6 cups	Moderate	1
Split Pea Soup Budget · High-protein	4	About 7 cups	High	1
Black Bean Soup with Salsa Budget · High-protein · Kid-friendly	4	About 1 cup	Low	1
Chicken and Rice Skillet High-protein · Comfort food	4	About 2 cups	Moderate	1
Vegetable Beef-Style Soup High-protein · Comfort food	4	About 7 cups	Moderate	1
Mac and Cheese with Broccoli Kid-friendly · Comfort food	4	About 8 cups for boiling	Moderate	1
Jambalaya-Style Rice High-protein · Comfort food	4	About 2 1/4 cups	Moderate	1
Tex-Mex Rice Bowls Kid-friendly · High-protein · Budget	4	About 2 cups	Moderate	1
Creamy Chicken and Noodles Comfort food · High-protein	4	About 6 cups for boiling	Moderate	1
Minestrone-Style Pantry Soup Budget	4	About 6 cups	Moderate	1
Salmon Rice Pilaf High-protein	3	About 2 cups	Moderate	1
Curried Rice and Lentils High-protein · Budget	4	About 3 cups	Moderate	1
Tomato-Tuna Rice Skillet High-protein · Budget	3	About 2 cups	Moderate	1
Ham and Split Pea Stew High-protein	4	About 6 cups	High	1
Alfredo-Style Pasta Kid-friendly · Comfort food	3	About 6 cups for boiling	Moderate	1
Spanish Rice with Black Beans Budget · High-protein	4	About 2 cups	Moderate	1
Chili Potato Skillet Kid-friendly · High-protein · Comfort food	3	About 1 1/4 cups	Low	1
Pancakes from the Pantry Breakfast · Kid-friendly · Comfort food	3	About 1 1/2 cups	Moderate	2
One-Pot Rice and Chicken Soup High-protein · Comfort food	4	About 7 cups	Moderate	1
Bean and Cheese-Style Bowls Kid-friendly · High-protein · Budget	4	About 1 cup	Low	1

Method for all rows: One-pot meals. Every recipe also carries the standard label-verification note: check the nutrition label for your chosen brand.

Recipes by tag

Emergency breakfasts (11)

Peanut Butter and Raisin Crackers · Granola Breakfast Bowl · Peanut Butter Tortilla Roll-Ups · Applesauce Granola Cups · Overnight-Style Oats with Peanut Butter · Cinnamon Cereal Cups · Peanut Butter Oatmeal · Breakfast Couscous with Cinnamon · Cinnamon Raisin Oatmeal · Savory Oats with Egg and Bouillon · Pancakes from the Pantry

Child-friendly (31)

Tuna Salad on Crackers · Chickpea Smash Sandwiches · Peanut Butter and Raisin Crackers · Granola Breakfast Bowl · Ham and Cheese Cracker Stack · Peanut Butter Tortilla Roll-Ups · Applesauce Granola Cups · Fruit Parfait Cups · Pantry Snack Board for Kids · Bean Dip and Chips · Cinnamon Cereal Cups · Peanut Butter Oatmeal · Upgraded Ramen Bowl · Instant Mash and Gravy Chicken Bowl · Thermos Tomato Pasta · Creamy Tomato Soup with Pasta · Mac and Cheese Cup · Chili Over Instant Potatoes · Thai-Style Peanut Noodles · Cheddar Potato Soup · Cinnamon Raisin Oatmeal · Chili Mac · Chicken Noodle Soup from Cans · Pasta with Marinara · Black Bean Soup with Salsa · Mac and Cheese with Broccoli · Tex-Mex Rice Bowls · Alfredo-Style Pasta · Chili Potato Skillet · Pancakes from the Pantry · Bean and Cheese-Style Bowls

High-protein (44)

Tuna Salad on Crackers · Chickpea Smash Sandwiches · Mediterranean Chickpea Salad · Salmon Salad on Crispbread · White Bean and Olive Salad · Ham and Cheese Cracker Stack · Black Bean and Corn Salsa Salad · Sardine Toast with Mustard · Pantry Antipasto Plate · Chicken Salad Wraps · Bean Dip and Chips · Jerky, Nuts and Dried Fruit Plate · Sardine and White Bean Mash · Couscous with Chicken and Peas · Instant Mash and Gravy Chicken Bowl · Instant Rice and Black Beans · Red Lentil Stew · Chicken Congee with Instant Rice · Chili Over Instant Potatoes · Thai-Style Peanut Noodles · Savory Oats with Egg and Bouillon · Ham and Potato Soup · Bulgur Pilaf with Chickpeas · Chili Mac · Pantry Three-Bean Chili · Red Beans and Rice · Chicken Noodle Soup from Cans · Tuna Noodle Skillet · Hearty Lentil Soup · Split Pea Soup · Black Bean Soup with Salsa · Chicken and Rice Skillet · Vegetable Beef-Style Soup · Jambalaya-Style Rice · Tex-Mex Rice Bowls · Creamy Chicken and Noodles · Salmon Rice Pilaf · Curried Rice and Lentils · Tomato-Tuna Rice Skillet · Ham and Split Pea Stew · Spanish Rice with Black Beans · Chili Potato Skillet · One-Pot Rice and Chicken Soup · Bean and Cheese-Style Bowls

Evacuation-ready (15)

Tuna Salad on Crackers · Peanut Butter and Raisin Crackers · Salmon Salad on Crispbread · Granola Breakfast Bowl · Ham and Cheese Cracker Stack · Peanut Butter Tortilla Roll-Ups · Sardine Toast with Mustard · Pantry Antipasto Plate · Chicken Salad Wraps · Pantry Snack Board for Kids · Trail Mix Energy Bowls · Cinnamon Cereal Cups · Jerky, Nuts and Dried Fruit Plate · Thermos Tomato Pasta · Miso-Style Noodle Cup

Low-water (15)

Tuna Salad on Crackers · Peanut Butter and Raisin Crackers · Granola Breakfast Bowl · Ham and Cheese Cracker Stack · Peanut Butter Tortilla Roll-Ups · Sardine Toast with Mustard · Fruit Parfait Cups · Pantry Snack Board for Kids · Trail Mix Energy Bowls · Cinnamon Cereal Cups · Jerky, Nuts and Dried Fruit Plate · Couscous with Chicken and Peas · Breakfast Couscous with Cinnamon · Tabbouleh-Style Couscous Salad · Dehydrated Vegetable Soup

Budget (36)

Chickpea Smash Sandwiches · Peanut Butter and Raisin Crackers · Mediterranean Chickpea Salad · White Bean and Olive Salad · Black Bean and Corn Salsa Salad · Peanut Butter Tortilla Roll-Ups · Applesauce Granola Cups · Fruit Parfait Cups · Overnight-Style Oats with Peanut Butter · Bean Dip and Chips · Trail Mix Energy Bowls · Sardine and White Bean Mash · Peanut Butter Oatmeal · Upgraded Ramen Bowl · Instant Rice and Black Beans · Creamy Tomato Soup with Pasta · Miso-Style Noodle Cup · Red Lentil Stew · Mac and Cheese Cup · Cinnamon Raisin Oatmeal · Dehydrated Vegetable Soup · Instant Polenta with Tomato Sauce · Bulgur Pilaf with Chickpeas · Pantry Three-Bean Chili · Red Beans and Rice · Pasta with Marinara · Tuna Noodle Skillet · Hearty Lentil Soup · Split Pea Soup · Black Bean Soup with Salsa · Tex-Mex Rice Bowls · Minestrone-Style Pantry Soup · Curried Rice and Lentils · Tomato-Tuna Rice Skillet · Spanish Rice with Black Beans · Bean and Cheese-Style Bowls

Tags are not exclusive — a recipe appears under every category it satisfies. The full cards for all 70 recipes are in Chapters 5 and 6.

Appliance thermometers	Ch. 3, 9	Mylar bags / oxygen absorbers	Ch. 9
Bleach water treatment	Ch. 3	No-cook meals	Ch. 5
Bouillon / broth	Ch. 8	Oats	Ch. 5–6 recipes
Budget building	Ch. 4	Older adults	Ch. 8
Camp stoves / grills	Ch. 10	One-pot meals	Ch. 6
Canned food safety	Ch. 9	Pancakes	Ch. 6 (op24)
Carbon monoxide	Front matter, Ch. 10	Pantry inventory	Back matter
Car kits	Ch. 11	Peanut butter	Ch. 5, 8
Children, feeding	Ch. 8	Pets	Ch. 3, 12
Couscous	Ch. 6	Playbooks, disaster	Ch. 11
Date labels	Ch. 9	Powdered eggs / milk	Ch. 2, 8
Disasters — hurricanes	Ch. 11	Protein sources	Ch. 8
Disasters — floods	Ch. 11	Ready-to-eat proteins	Ch. 2, 5
Disasters — winter storms	Ch. 11	Recipe scoring / taste tests	Ch. 7, back matter
Disasters — tornadoes / earthquakes / wildfires	Ch. 11	Rotation system	Ch. 7, 9
Dry ice	Ch. 9	Shelf life	Ch. 9
Evacuation meals	Ch. 5, 11	Sodium strategies	Ch. 8
Flavor system	Ch. 8	Solar cookers	Ch. 10
Flood salvage	Ch. 9	Thermos cooking	Ch. 6, 10
Formula, infant	Ch. 8	Three-layer pantry	Ch. 2
Freeze-dried food	Ch. 4	Universal meal formula	Ch. 8
Fuel planning	Ch. 10, back matter	Water calculator	Ch. 3, back matter
Go-bags	Ch. 11	Water storage & treatment	Ch. 3
Home canning (policy)	Ch. 9	Worksheets	Ch. 12, back matter
Hot-water meals	Ch. 6	30-day menu grid	Ch. 7
Infants	Ch. 8	Use one, replace one	Ch. 7
Instant rice / potatoes	Ch. 6	When in doubt, throw it out	Front matter, Ch. 9
Jerky	Ch. 5, 8	Winter cooking safety	Ch. 10, 11

Ch. = chapter; "back matter" refers to the printable tools following Chapter 13.

About Food Opsec

Food Opsec is a practical-preparedness publisher focused on one idea: households are safest when their emergency plans are built from food they already know, like and can afford. The Food Opsec approach rejects fear-based marketing in favor of checklists, menus, rotation habits and honest math about cost, water and fuel.

The Emergency Food Playbook is the flagship of the Household Resilience Series. It was written against current U.S. federal guidance from FEMA, USDA, FDA, CDC and EPA, and designed to be printed, marked up, taped inside pantry doors, and used until the pages soften.

Preparedness is not a product you buy once. It is a Tuesday-night habit that pays for itself every time the lights go out.

Keep the system alive

Eat one pantry meal this month. Score it. Replace it. That single loop is the entire secret of the book.